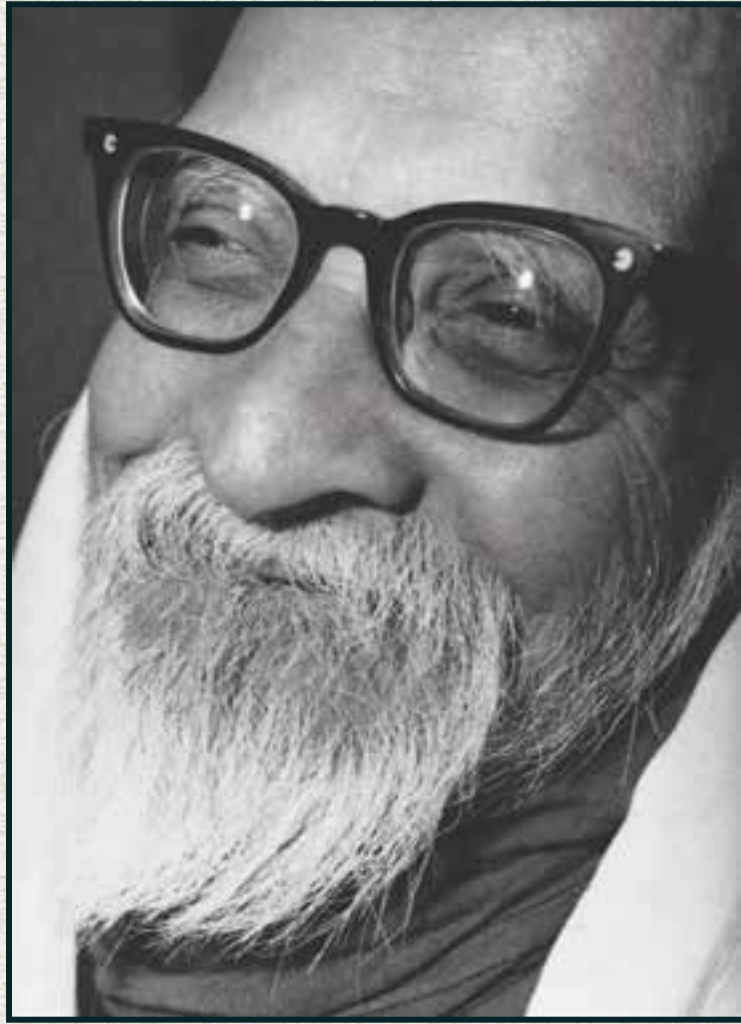




Photobiography of
Acharya Vinoba Bhave
in his own words

Photographs

Gautam Bajaj
Brahmvidya-Mandir
Paunar, Wardha 442111
Tel. 07152 – 288388

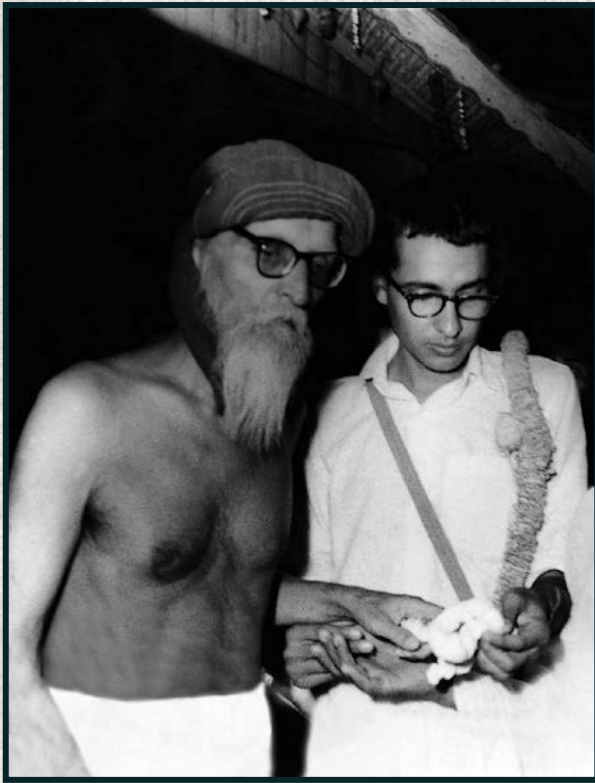
Editor

Usha
Gautam Bajaj

Art Direction

Sujata Bajaj, Paris

My thoughts...



Vinobaji was among the initial few who joined Gandhiji's *ashram* in Ahmedabad (1916). In accordance with Gandhiji's wishes, he shifted to Wardha in 1921 and began to look after the ashram there. Later, Paunar became his *karmbhoomi* (place of work). The early years in the ashram were spent in intellectual and spiritual pursuits as well as constructive work. Gandhiji had chosen him as the first *satyagrahi* of Individual satyagraha in 1940, and had brought him into the limelight.

After Gandhiji's passing, there were some communist insurgencies in Telangana (Andhra). On the 18th April 1951, while Vinobaji was walking around that disturbed area, he received the first donation of land for the poor and landless people. This was the beginning of an unprecedented peaceful movement called the *Bhoodan-yajna*. Vinobaji walked on foot for miles and miles all over the country for 13 long years. He asked for, and received, more than 4 million acres of land from landowners, for distribution among the landless.

Coming back from Telangana, Vinobaji spent the rainy season in Paunar ashram and on 12th September 1951, started his 1350 kms. *padayatra* (journey on foot) to Delhi.

I, too, had an opportunity to join the *padayatra*. My mother (Smt. Anasuya Bajaj) had handed me a small box and had told me to take photographs during the *padayatra*. I was twelve then. It was a box camera, costing nineteen rupees in those days. There were two rolls of film along with the camera, each worth two rupees and twenty five paise. Thus began my association with photography.

Two and a half months later, when we reached Delhi, an acquaintance of my mother helped me buy an Agfa 3.6 folding camera for a princely sum of two hundred rupees. I used this camera for many years. While returning to India after completing his studies in Germany, my younger brother Ashok spent all his savings on a Rolliflex camera for me. Later, Ashok presented me a 35mm Ashai Pentax as well.

The majority of photographs in this book have been taken between 1951 to 1982. They include photographs of the *padayatra* and *ashram*. Inexperienced as I was, in the beginning, I gave some negatives of special significance to friends, which were never returned. As a result, I resolved never to give negatives to anybody. While on the *padayatra*, I would get the films developed and send them to my mother. She kept them safe. In fact, she did not part with them even when my father asked for them. The films were developed in the cities and towns that we crossed. Substandard chemicals used in these places have contributed to the poor quality of prints. I have managed to put together photographs that survived all this. In addition, I have also been able to collect a few photographs from Shri Kanu Gandhi and Shri Mohan Parikh. Some photographs have been obtained from the collections of other friends, where the name of the photographer is not known. *Vinoba Darshan* has thus been made possible by the cooperation of various friends — known and unknown. I am grateful to all of them.

No photograph is available of Vinobaji's mother. She did not allow herself to be photographed. It was her belief that getting photographed was detrimental to one's inner lustre. She would say, "The physical body is transient. What is the point in having it photographed? It's much better to have pictures of the gods." Many years later, Vinobaji's younger brother, Shivaji Bhave, drew a line figure of his mother. That is the only available

likeness of her, and that has been included in this collection. Similarly, only a couple of photographs of Vinobaji's father are available. Vinobaji himself would never pose for photographs. Once, a friend asked for permission to photograph him. Vinobaji replied, "You can steal a photograph."

Very few photographs of Vinobaji himself are available from the period prior to the *Bhoodan padayatra*. Vinobaji felt that photographs of any person ought to be put up only after his passing. Once in Vinobaji's room someone put up a few big pictures of Vinobaji. Vinobaji refused to enter the room unless the pictures were removed. Sometimes, individual visitors or group of people would request for a photograph with him. Vinobaji would remark, "Last act of the drama!"

In 1952, during the *padayatra* in Bihar, thousands of people were listening to Vinobaji with rapt attention. The dais had been made by placing three platforms, one on top of the other, Vinobaji sat on the top platform. A few children sat below it. It made a quaint picture. I wanted to capture this on camera, so I got up and started taking photographs. This distracted Vinobaji and the audience. Abruptly, Vinobaji's voice was heard on the loudspeaker, "Who is the fool disturbing the meeting?" Having been reprimanded in public, I promptly sat down. Following this incident, I avoided Vinobaji for a couple of days. He, however, had completely forgotten about the incident very next moment.

In 1964, Vinobaji had a ear problem, due to which he would lose his balance. Sometimes he would feel giddy even while sitting. He needed support to walk. Once, when I was trying to photograph him, he said, "You will prove to be a true photographer if you continue taking photographs of me, instead of supporting me, when I lose balance and fall." And then he burst into laughter. Laughing long had become a one point programme for him in his later years. Life for him was nothing but sublime joy.

The *padayatra* was full of unique experiences. We once had to cross a river on an elephant. There were times when we had to wade through chest-deep water, holding each other's hands, balancing out bags on our heads. We walked through crowded cities and deserted jungles. Swift rivers, flowing with full force, had to be crossed using trunks of tress as bridges. In the jungles of Koraput, we had to cross the same river eight times in single day. Occasionally we had to camp-out in the open under the canopy of twigs and branches as there was no village in sight for miles together.

Floods in Assam, with submerged roads and fields, meant that we had to go from one village to another by boat. We sometimes had to directly step into the boat from our lodgings. In Bihar, due to floods, Vinobaji had to address a gathering from a boat. The thousands who had come to listen to him were also seated in hundreds of boats. It was pure joy in Kerala among the backwaters and coconut trees. In Tamilnadu, we walked between lush fields of rice. Sometimes, having lost our way in pathless jungles, we would just walk on. We had walked continuously from four in the morning till four in the afternoon, the day we reached Kotadwar.

Once a speeding bicycle collided with Vinobaji from behind. He fell down and injured his knees. Even then the *yatra* could not be stopped. He continued the *yatra* in a bullock-cart. However, in places where a bullock-cart could not be used, he was carried on a chair. This way, we crossed the Shivalik hills. Sometimes he would start running with the children — making it difficult for the elderly to catch up with him. Once an elderly gentleman tripped on his *lungi* and fell down while trying to run along.

At the confluence of the three seas in Kanyakumari, with the rising sun as witness, he took an oath to keep walking till he had strength in his limbs. In Assam there would be day long journeys on the river Brahmaputra in boats. Vinobaji would be roaming on the decks for hours. It was sheer joy to keep marching on through relentless rain, chanting verses from Vedas. Assam is famous for downpours. During these downpours, Vinobaji would never try to keep himself away from the rain. While thousands of people in his audience stood around with umbrellas, he would let the rain soak him through. He would say that it was God's blessing pouring down upon him.

Among the tribals, he would hang their drum round his neck and sing merrily along with them. Walking in the valleys of Kashmir and crossing the snow-covered Pir Panjal mountains at an altitude of 13,500 feet is another indelible experience. In Bihar, the bundles of *Danpatras* (declarations of donations) had to be brought by truck. The bundles were stacked to form a dais from which Vinobaji made his announcement for *JillaDan* (gift of a whole district).... I remember number of such events of the *padayatra*. Only a few of them have been captured on film.

Over thousands of years, there have been many *padayatras* in India. However, I doubt if there ever has been one with the specific aim of alleviating a pressing problem of the poor; with the innate capacity to generate a moral and spiritual environment, and to equate revolution with peace.

Vinobaji stated that the aim of his life was *Jeevanam satya -shodhanam*. This refers to a search for the truth incorporated in the entire universe and the effort to make it materialize. This involves experiencing oneness with all creation. Ahimsa (non-violence) is the path to follow in order to experience truth. Ahimsa also implies an experience of love for the whole universe. Ahimsa is love and only love....It is difficult to perceive love unless it is expressed in some form or the other. It becomes tangible when it manifests itself as concern for the poor; an effort to unite hearts; and an expansion of the circle of compassion to include the whole of humanity and the universe. Without a firm foundation on the bedrock of compassion, the problems of the poor, the underprivileged, the sorrowful or the exploited remain unsolved. Without compassion, neither can a non-violent society be established, nor can the hope for peace in the world be realized.

This was the inspiration behind Vinobaji's life and work. Even Gandhiji's main idea behind *Swarajaya* (Independence) was truth, non-violence and the upliftment of the poor and the downtrodden. Vinobaji picked up the threads of this legacy and walked on for thirteen years. Brahmailydia-Mandir was born out of the *padayatra*. It was this desire to unite hearts that motivated Vinobaji to study the holy texts of various religions and enabled him to extract the essence from each of them.

My effort in compiling this book of photographs has been to present a *darshan* (vision) of Vinobaji's *tapasya* (religious penance), joyfully undertaken for spreading the message of compassion, and for uniting hearts. This pictorial book has three sections. The first section covers his childhood, up to the year 1950. The second section deals with the *Bhoodan Yatra* and the third section is about his years in *Brahmailydia-Mandir*, the Paunar Ashram.

Vinobaji's life was a life devoted to *Karmayoga* (the way of selfless action). The first phase of his life can well be classified under *Karmayoga based on intense spiritual Sadhana*; the Bhoodan phase under *Karmayoga born of Compassion*; the last phase under *Karma in Akarma* (action in inaction) — peaceful, silent, subtle *Karmayoga*. From another angle, the first phase of his life can also be called *Gyanayoga* (path of wisdom), the second, *Bhaktiyoga* (path of devotion) and the last *Dhyanayoga* (path of meditation). However, Vinobaji himself never differentiated between *Gyana*, *Dhyana*, *Bhakti* and *Karma*. His experience of life was One, Unified, Undifferentiated, Whole. Therefore these sections are only broad categories.

From Vedic times to the present age, the role of Indian saints and sages has always been to lead society towards liberation. We witnessed the same vision behind Vinobaji's entire work.

The words in this book are Vinobaji's. However, in some places, the editors have described the pictures. These descriptions are given in *italics*.

We have chosen not to keep the copyright of Vinobaji's pictures, as he always exhorted us to renounce ownership. Anyone can make appropriate use of these pictures. However, we would appreciate, if we are informed.

Apart from the photographs, a number of people have helped to put together this book. Jain Irrigation Systems of Jalgaon assisted with the primary layout; Sujata Bajaj and Vinaybhai with the presentation of photographs. The 'end papers' are drawn by Sujata and the cover is designed by Vinaybhai. Ushaben has been associated with this

book from conception to completion. She has been particularly responsible for choosing Vinobaji's words to go with each picture. We are also grateful to Shri Parag Cholkar, Yasminben and Prabha Desikan for presenting the Hindi version in English.

What belongs to the people is dedicated unto them.

Gautam Bajaj

हम यह अनुभव
करते हैं कि
यह सब

Search for the
Absolute

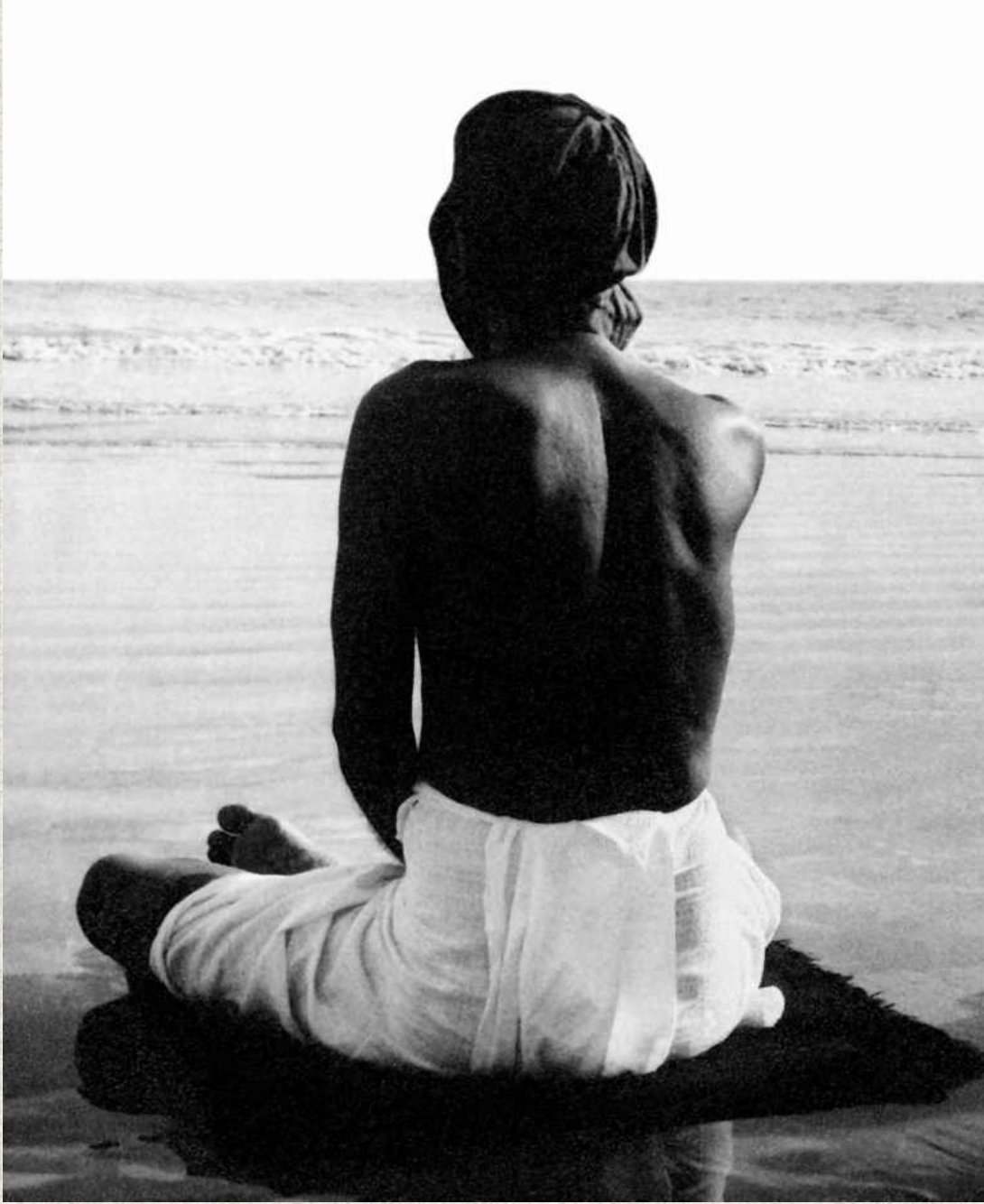


Move on, Move on



Peace, Benevolence,
Oneness

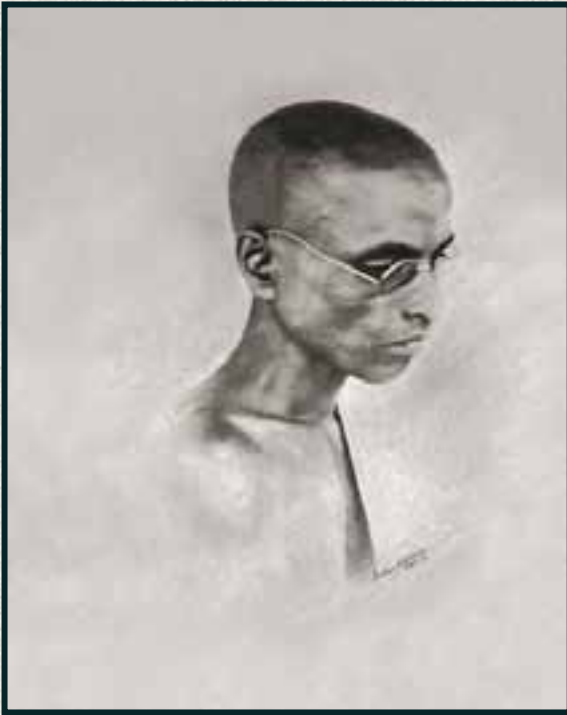




अथातो ब्रह्मजिज्ञासा

Search for the Absolute

Childhood, Renunciation, Ashram life, Constructive work



When I was ten years old I resolved to follow the path of *brahmacharya* — to remain celibate and devote the life to spiritual quest. Already, even in childhood, I was thinking about leaving home. I had three great examples before me—Gautam the Buddha, the Maharashtrian saint Ramdas and Shankaracharya, the world teacher. I therefore gave my attention to making sure that I did not go out into the world raw, or 'half-baked'. I prepared myself by study and meditation. I also tried to make my body a fit instrument for spiritual discipline.

I had a great affection and devotion for my father and mother. But love and attachment for them could not stop me from leaving home. Everything else paled before the force of the spiritual quest.

Truth leads us to the Lord. Search for Truth is the *raison d'être* of life. I had composed a couplet that reads — ***Brahma satyam, jagat sphoortih, jeevanam satyashodhanam.*** (Brahma is the Supreme Truth that has pervaded the cosmos. The world is its vibrant manifestation. Search for this Truth is the mission of life.) That is what life means to me.



*Gagode—a tribal hamlet with 80-85 huts,
situated in the midst of hillocks,
near India's western coast.*



The house built of bricks and mortar, at the centre of the village, belonging to Shambhurao Bhave, the inamdar (a kind of landlord) of the area and a very devout man. In this house Rukmini, his daughter-in-law, gave birth to Vinayak on September 11, 1895. The first nine years of Vinayak's life were spent in the company of his devout grandfather and the surrounding hills where he roamed about.



Shambhurao and Gangabai: the paternal grandparents



Maternal grandfather Balwantrao Vaidya, who had an ear for music



*Narhar Bhave — the father.
He was in the service of the
native state of Baroda in
Western India. In 1904,
Vinayak left Gagode and
accompanied his father
to Baroda.*

My father gave me plenty of beatings when I was a boy. He would be sure to discover some kind of mischief or disorderliness in my day's doings—there was always some reason for a beating. It had become a daily routine. But one day he did not beat me. The same thing happened the next day, and the next, and the day after that. He never beat me again. I found out the reason behind it later, when I read Manusmriti (the code of Manu). Manu has said, 'When your son reaches the age of sixteen you should treat him as a friend.' On the day I entered my sixteenth year he stopped beating me. As the beating stopped I became more responsible in my behaviour. The beatings were to point out what was wrong with my behaviour and nature; it was a kindness on his part, and I am grateful to him for that. His memories are deeply etched on my heart.

He was scientific in everything he did. His food intake was regulated. He was by nature very self-reliant. He was extremely punctual and self-disciplined. He was a yogi, mathematician and scientist. There was regulation and moderation in all his habits. He carried out a lot of experiments with dyes. During his later years he studied Indian classical music with a Muslim musician, and would practise as much as eight hours a day.

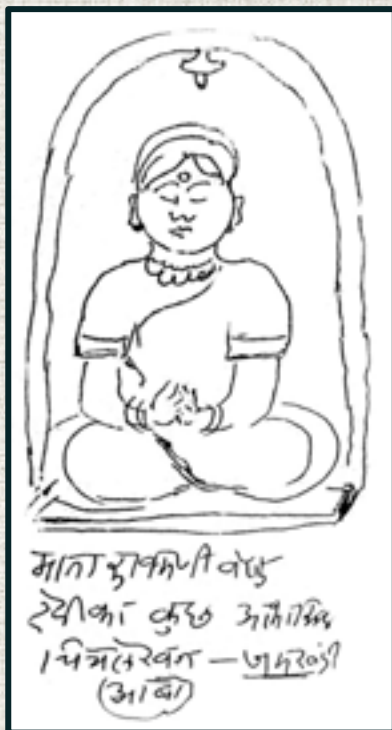
It is God's grace that I had such self-disciplined parents. In 1913 both of them took a vow of celibacy. Mother was thirty-seven years old at that time and father was thirty-nine.



The house at Baroda



*Dyed handkerchief with alphabets on
it, made by Narhar Bhave for
the children*



*Mother's sketch by Shivaji,
Vinobaji's younger brother*

Not a single photograph of my mother is available. Whenever she was asked to pose for one, she would say, 'Physical body is transient; what is the point in having its photograph? We should better have pictures of the deities.'

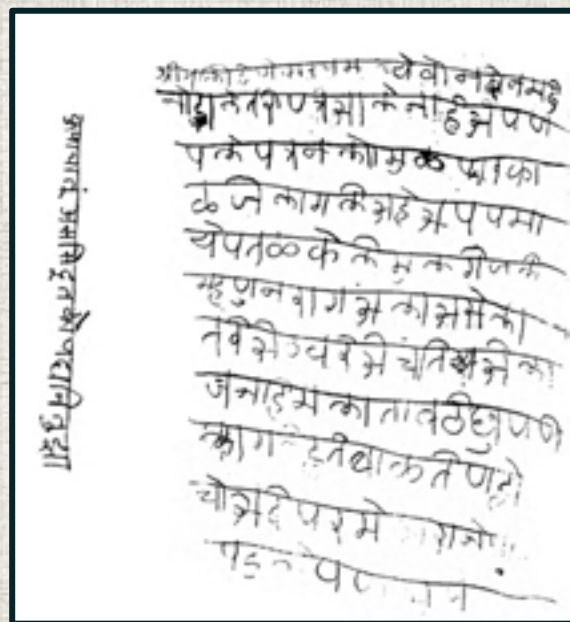
My mother was widely respected for the qualities of her heart. When she died, not a few persons remarked, 'She was a great *yogini*!'

She was illiterate, but was a great devotee. She would finish her household chores by noon and then would worship the Lord for about fifteen minutes, forgetting everything around her. At the end she would bow before the Lord and pray, 'O Lord of this boundless universe, forgive me for my faults!' while tears would roll down her cheeks. It was as if she was in direct communion with the Lord.

She was an ordinary housewife, busy all day long with her work, but her mind dwelt continually on the Lord. She lived in the world, but the world was neither in her mind nor on her lips. I have spent time in the company of many good men. I have read the books of many of the great, filled with the wisdom of experience. But if I were to put all that in one pan of the scales, and in the other what I learned of practical devotion from my mother, that second pan would carry the greater weight of value.

Some of my mother's words that have had a great influence on me are:

- 'One who gives is a god; one who hoards is a demon.'
- 'Remember, small is sweet; much is mischief.'
- 'Food sufficient to fill the stomach and cloth to cover the body; that is all we need.'
- 'If there were no saintly spirits to give the world the strength of their austerities, how could it survive?'



The only letter written by Vinobaji's mother with a pencil



There were about ten to fifteen of us friends, and we all wanted to undertake some social service. In 1914 we formed 'Vidyarthi Mandal' (Student Society). It held regular celebrations of the birthdays of Shivaji, Ramdas etc. We would also study various subjects and have discussions and talks on them. We put together a good library with about 1600 books. It was in this Society that my public life began. Many of the friends I made in it have remained my friends for life and have never left me. When I left home, many like Raghunath Dhotre, Babaji Moghe, Gopalrao Kale also left home and joined me. They stayed with me all their lives.

Yet, my real friends are the saints like Namdev, Jnanadev, Tukaram, Ramdas, Nanak, Tulsidas, Kabir, Narsi Mehta, Shankardev and

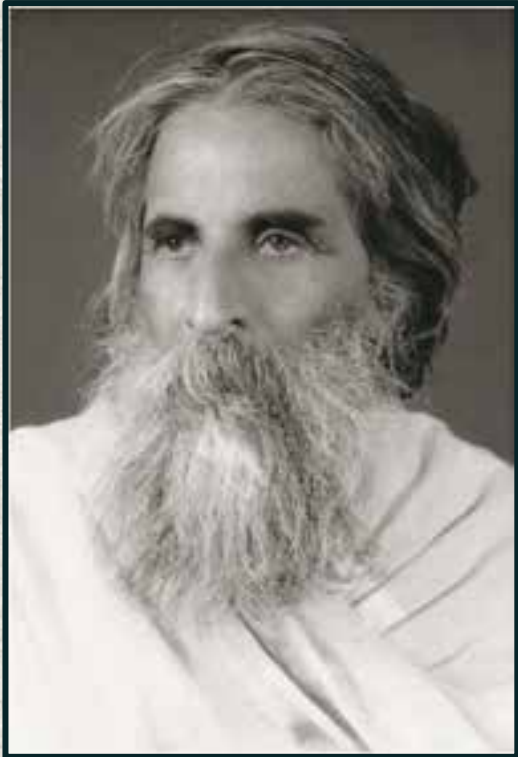
Madhavdev. And Shankaracharya, Ramanuja, Mahavir, Buddha, Vyasa, Valmiki, Shuka, Jesus, Mohammed too have been my bosom friends since my childhood. I have therefore never felt lonely.



With younger brothers, Balkoba and Shivaji

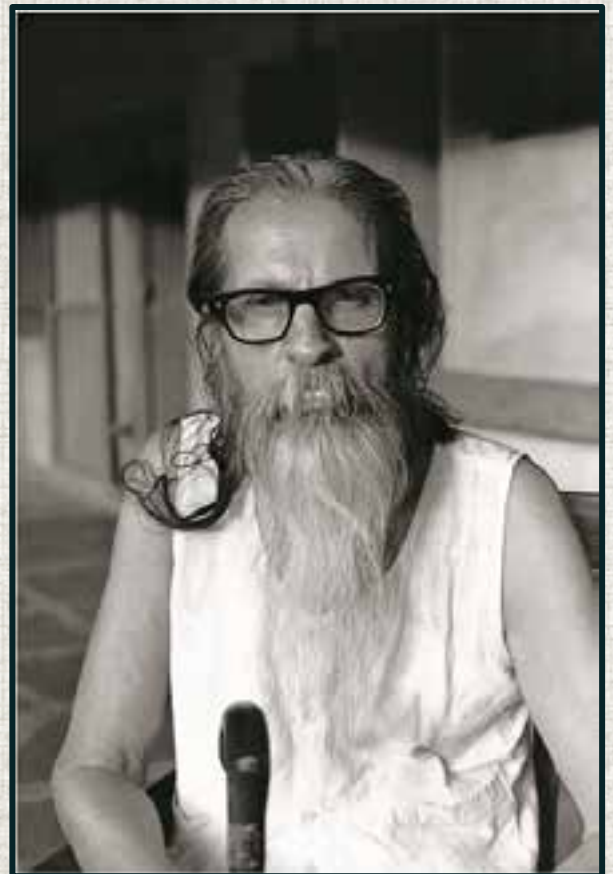
After I left home, both my younger brothers did the same; within two or three years they too left home and joined me. And they too remained celibate.

Balkoba is younger to me by five years. Shivaji is younger to him by three years. Both of them have devoted their lives to the spiritual quest. I feel blessed to have such brothers.

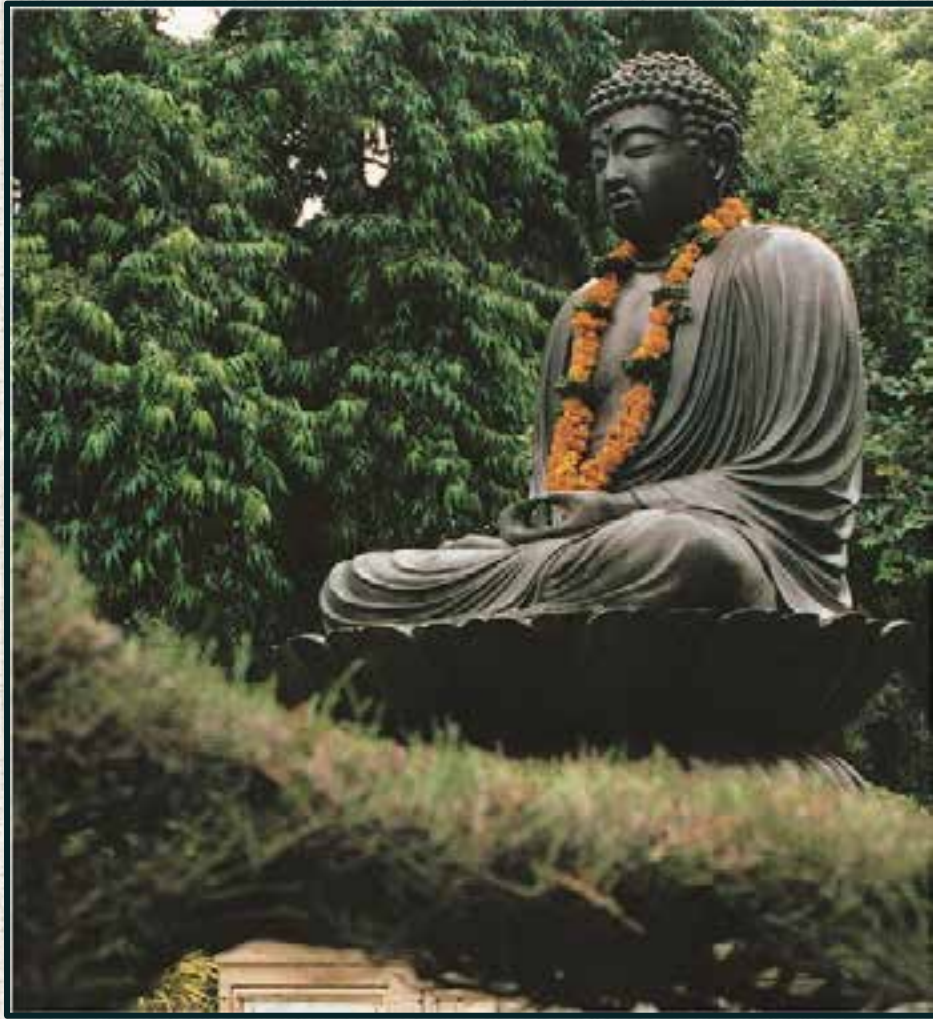


*Balkoba is a gift of God to me. He is as pure as a flower. He looks after me like a mother. — **Gandhiji***

The spiritual awakening that I find in Balkoba is rare in this age. There are some men in whose company no impure thought can enter your mind. Balkoba is one among them.



Shivaji is touring continuously propagating the message of Gitai. He is always busy in studying Gita and Gitai. He has always been inclined towards the pursuit of knowledge. Gitai has turned his eyes inwards.



I was greatly attracted to the statue of Lord Buddha in the Jubilee Gardens at Baroda, because the thought of leaving home was in my mind. I often went there to contemplate. It had a great influence on me.

The thought of leaving home had come to me first in 1912. For four years I tested myself rigorously before making my final decision - - - In those days one had to go to Mumbai for the Intermediate Examination. I set off from Baroda for Mumbai, but left the train at Surat and took the train for Varanasi. I wrote to my father, 'Instead of going to Mumbai for the examination, I am going somewhere else. You may be assured that wherever I go I shall do nothing that is wrong.' That day was March 25, 1916.

At the time of leaving home, I was firm in my mind that my life would be devoted to the spiritual quest along with social service. I was thus clear about the philosophy and mission of my life.

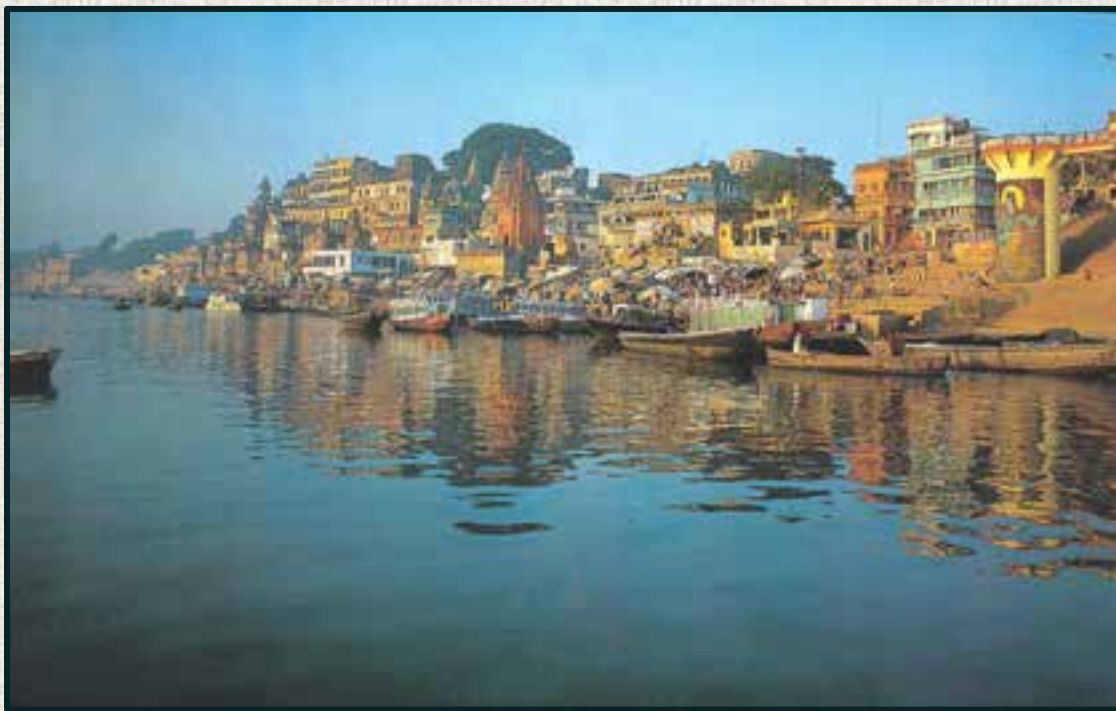


In my pursuit of Spiritual Reality, I left home and arrived at Varanasi. I found a place to live on the second floor of a house at Durga Ghat. One of my two companions went back home after a short time; the other remained with me. But he died there.

Initially I used to go to a charitable kitchen for my midday meal, where I would get two paise (about 3% of a rupee) as *dakshina*, according to the custom. They were enough to buy a supper of curds and sweet potatoes.

I also taught English in a private school for an hour or so, and earned four rupees in two months.

Every evening I spent an hour by the side of the river Ganga. Sometimes I sat in meditation or in deep thought, sometimes I composed poems which I then consigned to the river - - - I spent two months and a few days at Varanasi and then turned my steps towards Bapu (Gandhiji).





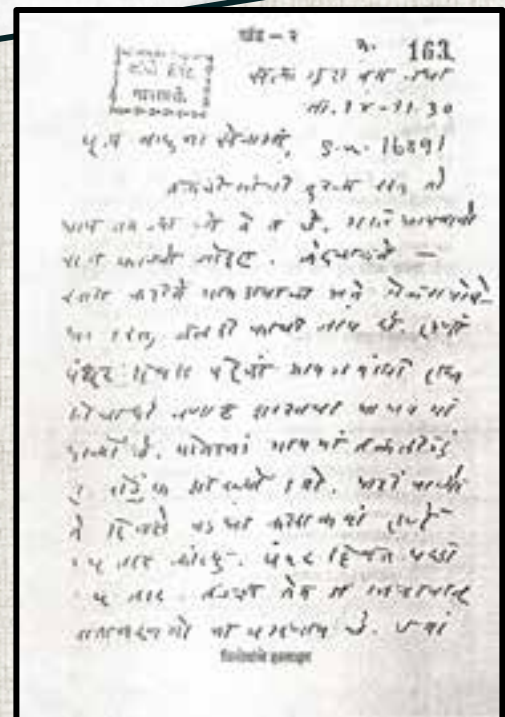
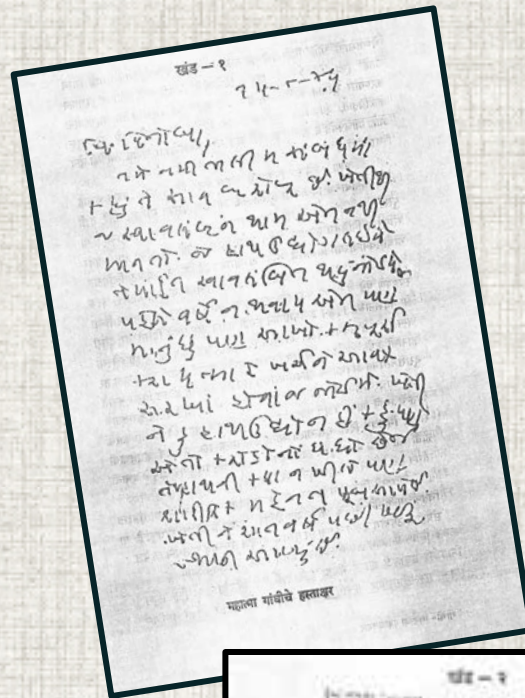
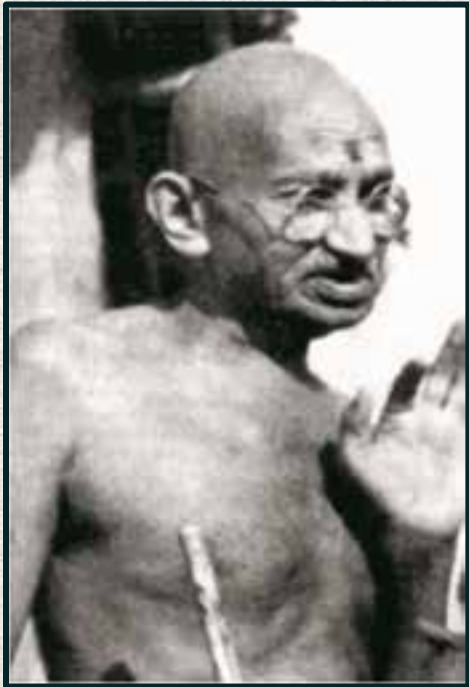
Gandhiji's hut at the Sabarmati Ashram

When I reached Varanasi, a speech that Gandhiji had delivered there was the talk of the town. In it he had spoken a great deal about non-violence. I read the speech and started corresponding with him. Finally he wrote, 'Your questions about non-violence cannot be settled by letters. It is life that will convince you. Come and stay with me for a few days in the Ashram.' So I went to him. That day was June 7, 1916.



Vinobaji's hut at the Sabarmati Ashram

I was attracted by the Ashram rules. 'The object of the Ashram', it was mentioned, 'is service of the country in such ways as are consistent with the welfare of the world as a whole', and eleven vows were listed as necessary to attain that object: Truth, non-violence, non-stealing, *brahmacharya*, non-possession and so on. This struck me as very surprising.



During my boyhood I had already been attracted by the revolutionary spirit of Bengal and the peace of the Himalayas. Eventually I went neither to Bengal nor to the Himalayas; I went to Gandhiji, and found in him both— the peace and the revolutionary spirit. Here was a man, I felt, who aimed at one and the same time at both political freedom and spiritual development.

I met Gandhiji and the unity in him between the inward and the outward captivated me. It was Gandhiji who initiated me into *karmayoga* (yoga of selfless action). It was on account of living with him that I became absorbed in service. I look upon service as a means of worshipping the Lord. I learnt much from Gandhiji. It brought clarity to my thinking, particularly about absolute moral values.

From the time I met Gandhiji, I have spent my life in carrying out his orders. There was a time when I used to dream of doing some act of violence and sacrificing myself at the altar of the country to win acclaim. Gandhiji drove that demon out of my mind. In the Ashram I felt myself growing, day-by-day and year-by-year

Letters written by Gandhiji and Vinobaji to each other in their own handwriting

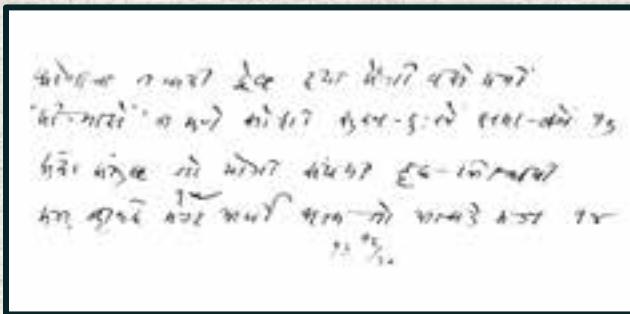
Vinoba is one of the few pearls in this Ashram. They do not come here like others to be blessed by the Ashram, but to bless it; not to receive, but to give. — Gandhiji

Your son, Vinoba, is with me. He has reached the spiritual heights for which I had to put in years of patient labour to reach.

(From Gandhiji's letter to Vinobaji's father, written in 1916)



At the earnest request of Jamnalalji Bajaj, Bapu decided to open a branch of the Satyagraha Ashram at Wardha, and directed me to take charge of it. So with one fellow-worker and four students I started work there on April 8, 1921.



Gitai in Vinoba's handwriting

It was my mother's faith in me, which made me translate the Gita into Marathi. I began the work on October 7, 1930 and finished it on February 6, 1931. I gave the name 'Gitai' to the translation.

The world may forget all that I have done, all the service that I have rendered; but it cannot forget 'Gitai' and my 'Talks on the Gita'. These works would continue to serve and benefit the world for years to come. When I wrote 'Gitai' and delivered the talks I was in a state of samadhi (a state of consciousness that transcends the world).



Mahilashram at Wardha, where Gitai was written

In my boyhood, I was fond of composing poems. When I found them satisfactory, I would offer them as a sacrifice to the god of fire. When I was at Varanasi, I would immerse the poems in the mother Ganga. I do not think that I, and the world also, lost anything thereby. I, in fact, believe that 'Gitai' is a gift of the god of fire and the mother Ganga.



I spent five years of my life in jail between 1923-1942. I had to do a lot of things there — cooking, rope-making, weaving, grinding, and even the hard labour of breaking stones.

I experienced a real Ashram life in jail. A few clothes, a tumbler and a bowl — that was all I had. What better place could there be for following the vow of non-possession? Bathing, eating, working according to rule, going to bed and getting up by the bell — it was a perfectly regulated life! The vow of ‘control of the palate’ had, of course, to be practiced everyday. There was also plenty of time for thinking and reflection. Spiritual discipline of the Ashram life can therefore be continued in the jail.

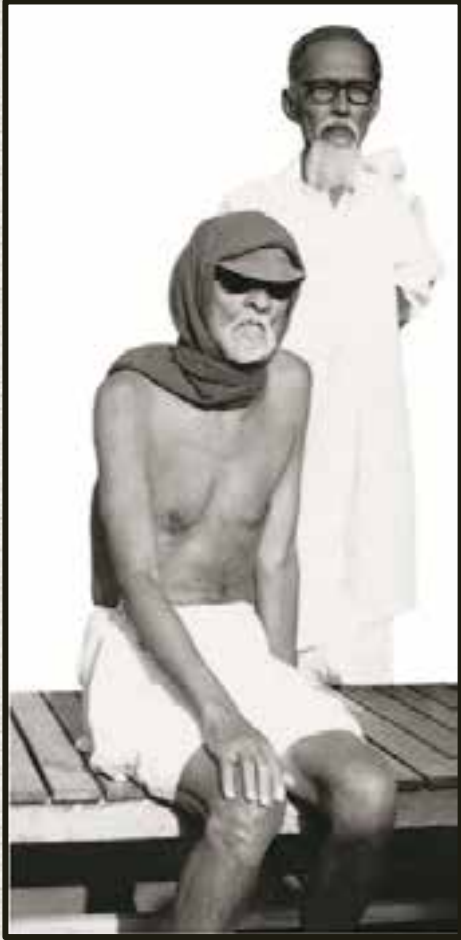
His spirit is pure as an angel; in scholarship, philosophy and religion he has reached the topmost heights. Yet so complete is his humility, so simple and straightforward his nature, that no official who does not already know him can discover what a great man he is. He does the tasks allotted to the C class of prisoners in which the gaoler has put him; he sits silently breaking stones, no one guesses what physical torture it costs him.

— **C. Rajgopalachari**

‘Talks on the Gita’ is the story of my life, and it is also my message.

At the instance of my fellow inmates in the Dhule jail, I agreed to give regular talks on the Gita and started to give a talk every Sunday. Sane Guruji wrote them all down, word for word. I cannot describe in words the state of my being while delivering these talks. If God ever speaks through human beings, then these are the words spoken by Him through me. While giving these talks I never felt that it was I who was speaking, and the listeners too did not feel that it was Vinoba who was speaking.





After I joined Gandhiji, I did many kinds of work. I used to spin or weave for hours. I paid attention to all the processes of khadi (handspun and handwoven cloth) production and carried out experiments in this regard. Once I began the sacred exercise of spinning four hanks of yarn daily in order to arrive at a fair wage for spinners. It used to take eight and half to nine hours.

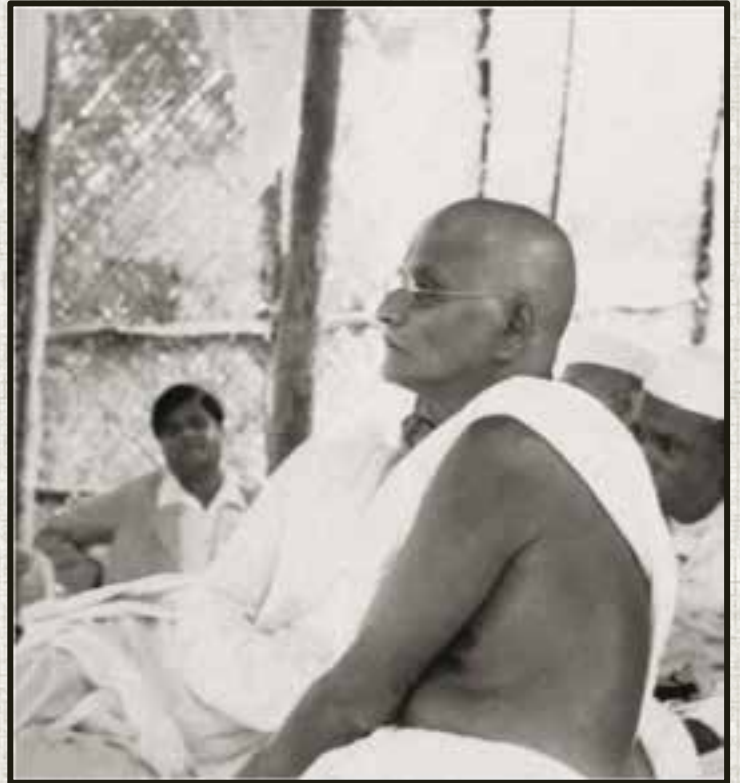
From 1932 onwards we began going from village to village, trying to be of service to the people. After two or three years, we came to the conclusion that a concrete plan for service ought to be chalked for the neighbouring villages. We therefore established Gramseva Mandal (Village Service Society) in 1934 and drew up a scheme for the whole of Wardha tehsil (subdivision of the district). Khadi, uplift of the Harijans (untouchables) and such other activities were started in a few selected villages.

During our visits to the villages, we noticed that leprosy was terribly common. We thought that this problem could not be ignored. Our friend Manohar Diwan was inspired to take it up and a leprosy centre was opened at Dattapur in 1936.



I look upon myself as a manual labourer. That is why I spent thirty-two years, the best years, of my life in that kind of labour. I undertook activities which human society cannot do without, but which in India are looked down upon as low and mean— scavenging (removing human excreta), weaving, carpentry, agricultural labour etc. I am a manual labourer by vocation, though by birth I am a *Brahmin*—which means one having a life of voluntary poverty and spiritual quest. Whatever I did, I did for self-realization.

I studied Economics in 1924. To make my studies realistic I lived on two annas (one-eighth of a rupee) a day, as that was the average per capita income of the lowest stratum of Indian society at that time. Now, what does this austerity and penance have to do with the study of Economics? I hold that we can properly digest any subject only when we adapt ourselves to it, and harness our faculties and senses accordingly. So I matched my standard of living with my study of Economics. That study benefitted me a great deal, and only the useful part of it was retained by my memory.



One of the chief causes of the inequality, crises and misery in society today is money. Money corrupts our social life. The saints, for the sake of spiritual discipline, always prohibited the use of money. Today it is necessary to prohibit it even to purify our normal social life. So we began the experiment of *kanchan-mukti* (doing without money) on January 1, 1950 at Pavnar.

Greed for money has made the life, even in our villages, miserable and dependent on others. If the villagers could satisfy their basic needs in the villages, they will be freed from the slavery of money, which is unreliable and deceitful by nature. Self-sufficiency of the villages in respect of food, clothing, housing, education, health and security is indispensable for a non-violent society.



When Jamnalalji opened the Laxminarayan temple at Wardha to the Harijans (Dalits), I had gone there. My gaze was fixed on the idol for some fifteen or twenty minutes. I was as if in a state of *samadhi*. Beholding the Lord's image from tip to toe, my eyes finally rested at His feet. There was no thought in my mind except to serve Him humbly.

There was once a theft at the Laxminarayan temple. Jamnalalji told Gandhiji about it. Gandhiji said, 'It is good that the Lord is relieved of the bondage and the thief got money. Both must be happy!' Jamnalalji replied, 'If both of them are happy, and Gandhiji is happy too, I too am happy!' The idol was then divested of its riches and was adorned with *khadi*.



In 1938, I was in poor health. Gandhiji pressed me to go to some place to regain health. I agreed to go to Pavnar (nine kms from Wardha). Gandhiji told me to leave behind the whole load of work and not to worry or think about any work. So when the car taking me to Pavnar reached the bridge on the river Dham, I repeated to myself three times over : 'I have renounced- renounced- renounced.' I thus reached Pavnar with a fully vacant mind.

Pavnar village was on one side of the river Dham and the place where I stayed was on the other. So I named it 'Paramdham'. (Literally, beyond the Dham; but it also means 'the ultimate abode'.) As my health steadily improved there, I had more and more contact with the village. Spinning and weaving were started there.



One day in Pavnar, while I was digging I struck something hard in the ground. It was a big stone. It turned out to be a fine piece of sculpture; the subject was the reunion of Rama and Bharata after fourteen years of separation. In 1932, while giving a talk on the Gita, I had said that had I been an artist I would have painted the scene depicting this reunion. This sculpture was just what I had then expressed in words. I took it as a gift from God, and therefore installed it in a shrine.



One fine morning in 1940 I got a message from Bapu asking me to go over and meet him. I went over at once. He said, 'I am in need of your help. I don't know whether you are free or not, but we have to start individual satyagraha now and I want you to get ready for it, if you can free yourself from other work without much trouble.' I laughed, 'In my eyes, your call is just about as imperative as that of Yamaraj—the god of death—himself. I don't even need to go back to Pavnar.' - - - During this satyagraha I was jailed thrice and spent about 21 months in different prisons.

The first satyagrahi chosen by Gandhiji for the individual satyagraha (1940)



With Gandhiji at the Faizpur Congress (1936)



The first satyagrahi in the individual satyagraha, with Jamnalalji Bajaj



The satyagraha begins

I started Satyagraha from Paunar village where I was residing. In a few days I was jailed. I was also imprisoned during the 'Quit India' movement. In all, I spent around five years in jail. I did a lot of study during those days. I studied many languages. I looked through Marx's works. I used to study for 14-15 hours daily. In Nagpur jail, I would listen to the Quran on the radio to learn the proper pronunciation of Arabic words.

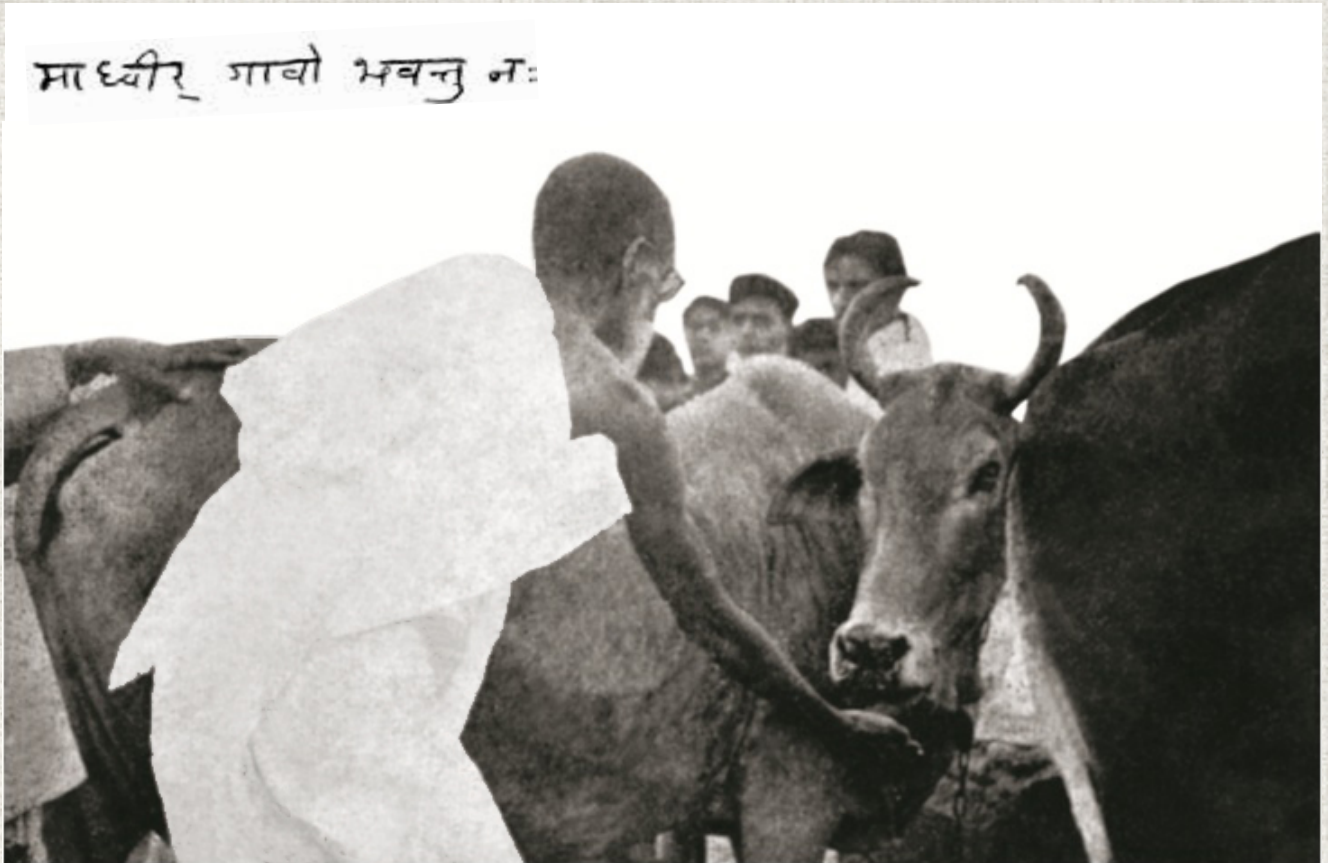


With Dr. Rajendra Prasad and Shriman Narayan, while returning after the immersion of Gandhiji's ashes at Pavnar



With Pandit Nehru, Prime Minister of India. Also seen in the picture are Pt. Ravishankar Shukla and Mrudula Sarabhai

In the Ashram I used to keep myself busy throughout the day with some or the other service activity. I spent thirty years of my life in quiet *sadhana*—in action, meditation, devotion and constructive work. During this period I devoted myself to spinning, service of the cows, village service, propagation of khadi, farming without the aid of bullocks or machines, running of workshops for those in need of work etc. I also worked for the rehabilitation of the Muslim Meos in India. I carried out the great experiment of *kanchan-mukti*. I am not a propagandist by nature; I am a humble seeker of Truth and a servant of the people. My quest has been for the purification of individual and social life. I derive joy and satisfaction from constructive work alone.

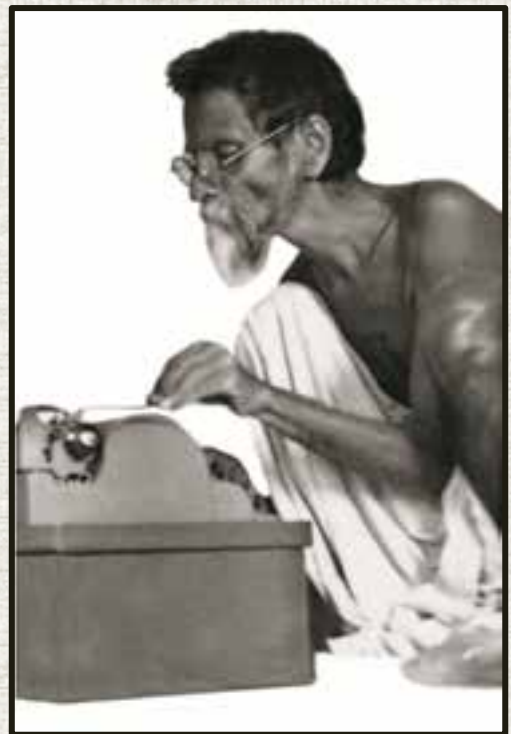




Kishorlal bhai was one of the rare few having a pure heart; one of those who have become dispassionate by the grace of God.

With Kishorlal Mashruwala

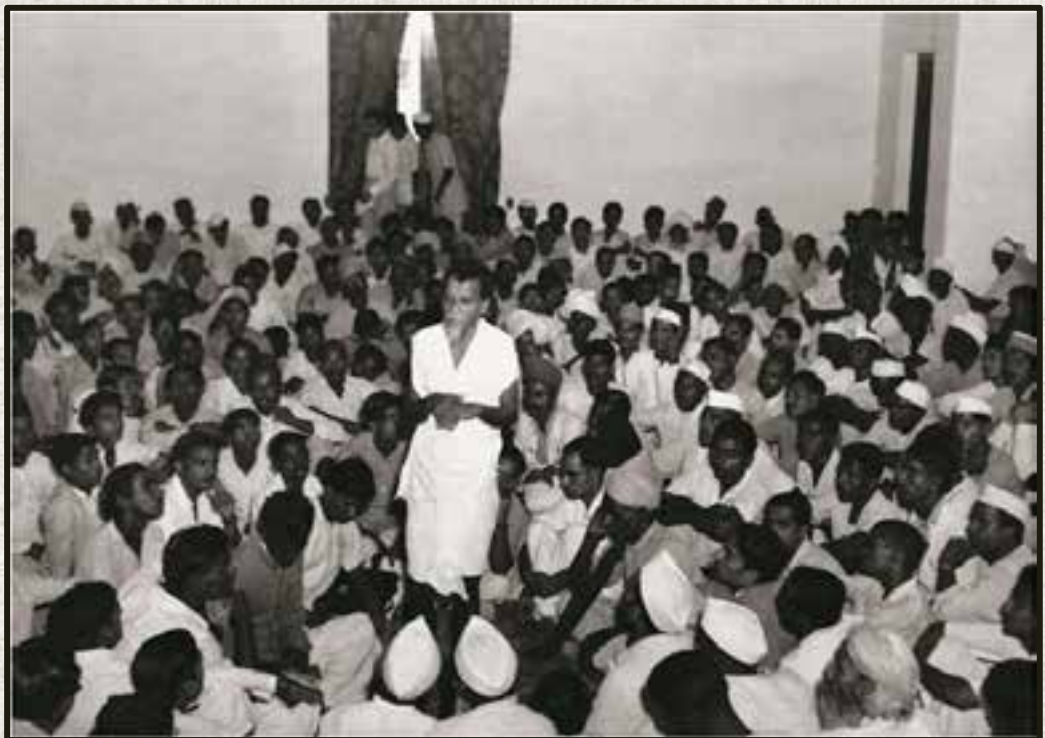
Nagari script is simple and scientific; yet it is not perfect. To remove its shortcomings and to enable it to have wide acceptance, Vinobaji made certain modifications in it and named the modified version 'Loknagari'. A typewriter with Loknagari alphabets was also put together. Quite a few books were published in this script. Vinobaji used this script in his correspondence for many years.





After Gandhiji's death, I agreed to give six months for the service of those made homeless by the partition of the country, on an experimental basis at the instance of Pandit Nehru. I worked hard. It did have some results. But I could not find the thing I was in search of. I did not feel that the power of non-violence can become manifest through such work.

Addressing a public meeting from a jeep

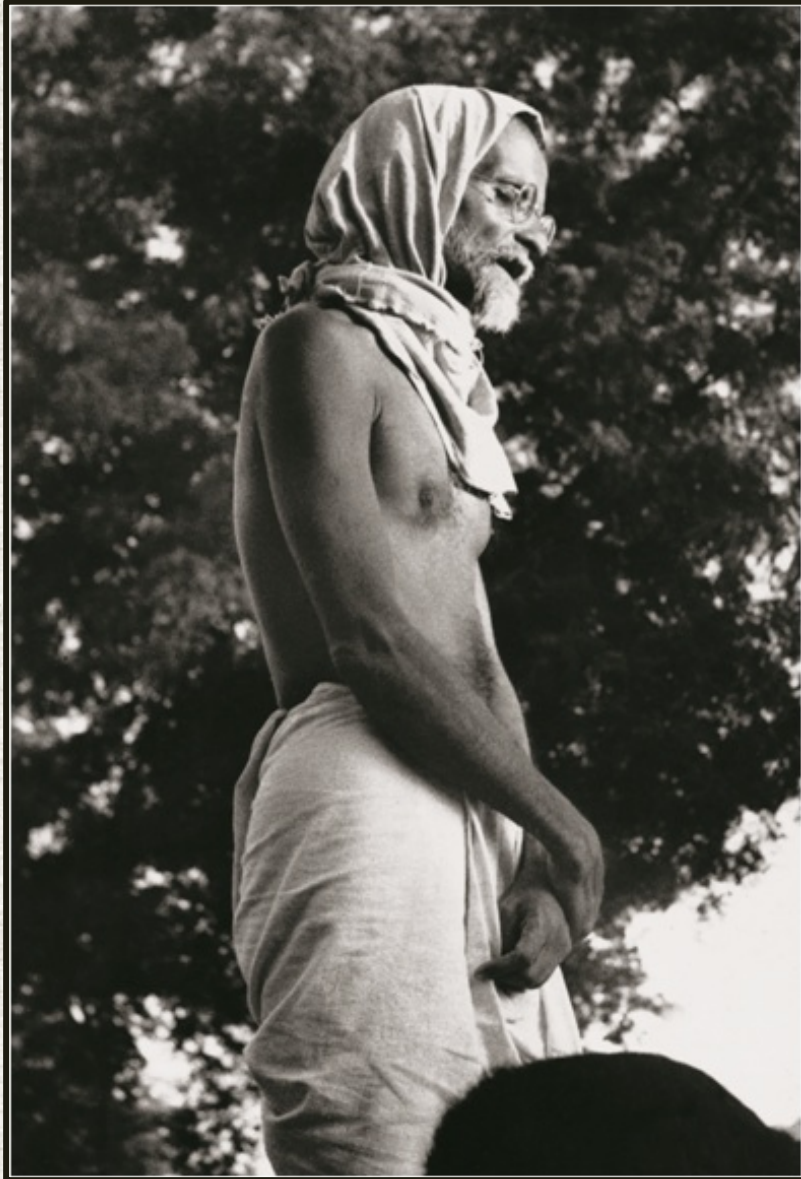


Among the Meos



In those days there were many conflicts between Hindus and Muslims. The Muslims of Ajmer felt they were in danger. So I stayed there for seven days, and visited the holy dargah everyday. That place is regarded as the Mecca of India. The Muslims welcomed me with great affection. At my instance, both Hindus and Muslims prayed together. The Muslims showered much love and trust on me.

In the dargah at Ajmer



Whatever God wills me to do will be done. I cannot draw a plan for myself; nor am I inclined to do so. If I could become an instrument in His hands, that is more than enough. I have no separate individual will of my own; and I do not want to have one.



चरैवेति चरैवेति

Move on, Move on

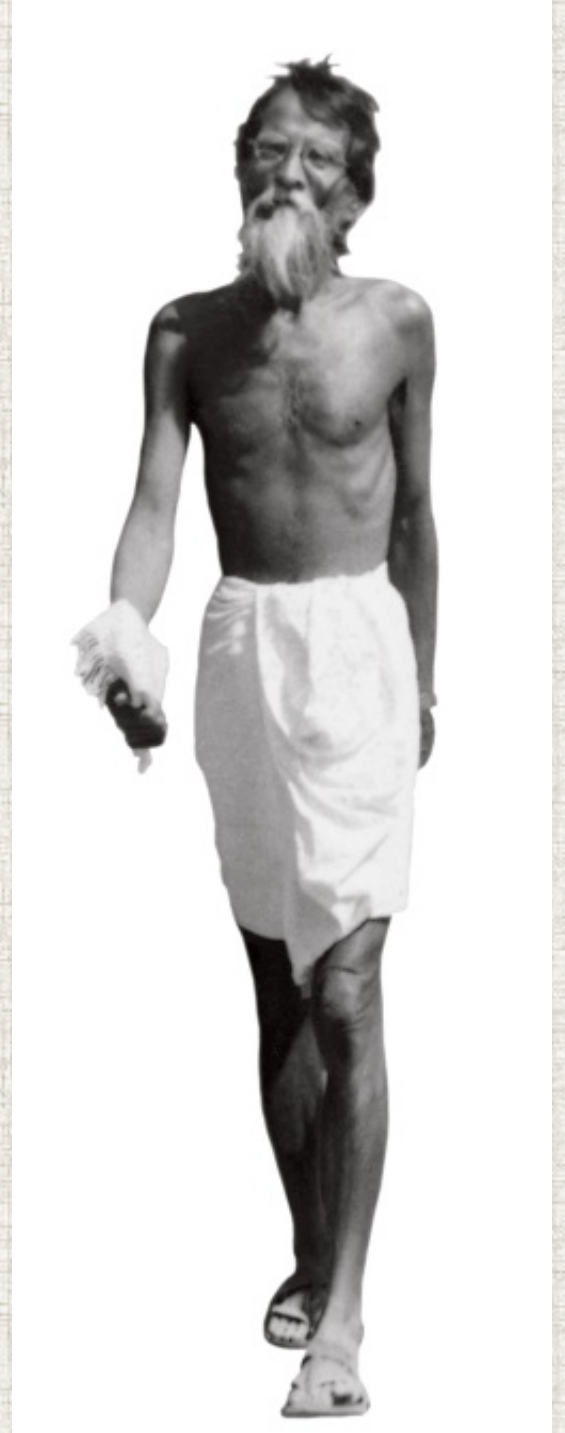
Journey on foot for Bhoodan

My body has been used to walking since my childhood. Walking has been a source of knowledge, creativity, energy and delight to me. When you walk in the open, under the boundless expanse of the sky, your heart too becomes large; pettiness and parochial tendencies wither away.

When a man is lying down, his whole body touches the ground. When he sits, a part of it touches the ground. When he stands up, his feet touch the ground. But when he starts walking, only one of his feet touches the ground. The lesser the contact with the earth, the greater is the contact with the heaven. That is why the scriptures say: *Charaiveti Charaiveti* (Move on, move on).

When we look down towards those who are less privileged and less fortunate, we feel compassion. When we look towards those who are more privileged and fortunate, we feel envy. Water always flows downwards; our compassion should also flow towards those more miserable than us. True compassion does not let man sit still. It is such compassion that is moving me; neither knowledge, nor renunciation, nor other-worldliness.

Going on foot brings one closer to the nature and to people than any other form of travel.





On way to Hyderabad

At Gandhiji's instance, I engaged myself in constructive work for about thirty years as best as I could. I did not feel like going out anywhere. After Gandhiji's death I had to travel, but that was mostly by car or by rail. I felt that I would not be able to achieve what I want, using these means. How can speedy forms of travel, which perturb the mind rather than helping deep contemplation, be useful for spreading the message of non-violence?

For me, provision of temporary relief to the people was not enough. What I was seeking, as a soldier of peace, was a technique for establishing peace which is essential for Sarvodaya. It occurred to me that I should travel about the country on foot. I seized the first opportunity to make a beginning in this direction in the Hyderabad state. That provided me a glimpse of the power of non-violence.

We are going on foot to Hyderabad, a distance of three hundred miles (480 kms). We would be walking fifteen miles daily on an average. Are we crazy? We are doing this to meet the people, to have a dialogue with them, to establish contact with them.

I do not want to know your religion or your views, but only what your troubles are. I want to help you to get rid of them.

— **Louis Pasteur**

(Vinobaji liked these words very much. He had written them down in his copy of the Upanishads)



Listening to the difficulties of the villagers



Talking with Shri Ramachandra Reddy, the first land-donor

Today the Harijans (Dalits) of this Pochampalli village came to see me. They said that if only they could get a bit of land, they could work on the land and so make a living. I told them to submit a petition which I would forward to the government. But a man who was present at the meeting offered to give the Harijans one hundred acres of his own land. I could not sleep that night. The incident set me thinking. All night long I pondered over what had happened. Was it a miracle? Or, had it any deeper significance? --- I realized that the power pervading the cosmos was preparing for something different. It had given an indication. The opportunity must be grabbed. The next day, in another village, I asked for the gift of land with confidence. The villagers had come with garlands to welcome me. I told them that I do not want the garlands; give me the soil instead. The people there were absolutely unprepared for such a demand. Yet I received twenty-five acres of land as gift. When two points are joined, we get a line. The first two gifts I received formed a line; now what was left to be done was its extension. Thus began the Bhoodan-yajna.

Whatever work I did in the ashrams or elsewhere, I have aimed at finding out how difficulties of every kind in the life of society, and in the life of individuals, may be overcome by non-violence. That is the main task before me. It was this mission that took me to Telangana.





A public meeting in Telangana

I have not come to beg; I have come to initiate you into something higher.

There are three ways of working in the world: violence, legislation and compassion.

The way of violence can never be beneficial to anybody. Legislation cannot generate independent power of the people. It is the way of compassion and love that we should take.

I want you to treat *Daridranarayan* (Lord in the form of the poor) who is starving, as a member of your family and give Him His due.



At the age of fifty-five I started my walking tour. It was as if I had become a child again at that age. I never considered myself an old man; nor a young man. I walked with the carefree spirit of a child.



Entry into Delhi (November 1951). Viyogi Hari is at the extreme right



I found great peace and inspiration at Gandhiji's memorial shrine at Rajghat (Delhi). I decided to stay there because of the feelings associated with it. Though God is to be found in every place, nevertheless the glory of some of the places is ineffaceable. It was Gandhiji whose inspiration is there behind the Bhoodan-yajna - - - My stay of eleven days at Rajghat (November 13-23, 1951) was spent in his holy presence.

I held discussions with the Planning Commission at Delhi and put forward my ideas very clearly.

No national planning is worthy of its name if it fails in providing full employment to all the people in the nation. Work for all and food for all—these ought to be its basic premises.

A member of the Planning Commission commented that it was not national planning; it was partial planning and some people would have to make sacrifices. I retorted, "If it is partial planning, then let the partiality be for the poor!" We should not sacrifice others; rather we should sacrifice ourselves.





Use of bullock-cart when the injured knee made walking impossible.



A cyclist once accidentally knocked down Vinobaji, injuring his knee. But the mission did not stop. When even a bullock-cart could not be used, he was carried on a chair. Picture shows Mahavir Tyagi, the then Central Minister of State for Finance, carrying the chair. (December 1951)



People ask me to which sect I belong. I belong to the community of mad men. I am crazy, and want to drive others crazy.

The walking pilgrimage during the first year was truly wonderful. I walked alone, and received 100,000 acres of land as gift. I walked on, without a care in the world. I remembered a line in one of Tagore's songs : 'Walk alone, O thou unfortunate, walk alone!' I modified it a bit to suit myself: 'Walk alone, O thou most fortunate, walk alone!'



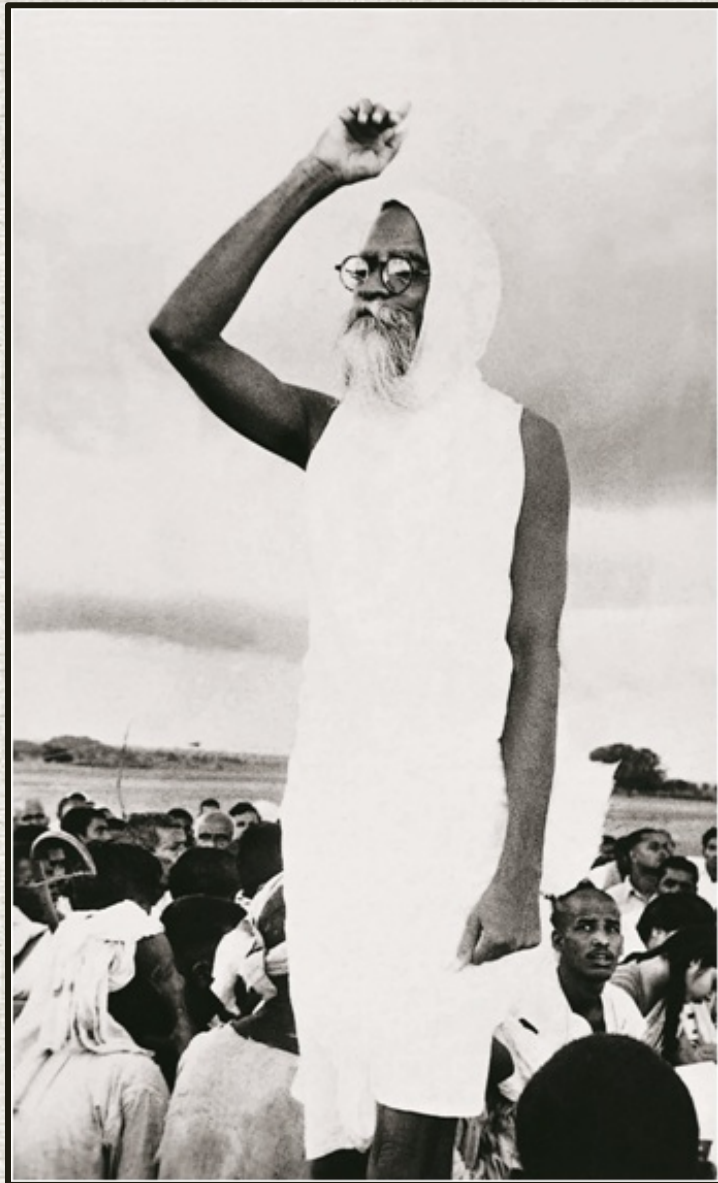
Trekking with luggage over his head



We have to establish equality in the country. No country can progress while keeping economic and social disparities intact. That is why one-third of the distributed bhoodan lands were given to the Harijans (Dalits).



Our poor are not only landless, they are also dumb. I am pleading their case as best as I can. I always make it clear that I am not begging for land; I am asking for the rightful share of the poor.



Like air, water and sunlight, land is also God's gift; and everybody has equal right over it—that is my usual refrain.



The first village I received as Gramdan was Mangaroth in Uttar Pradesh. In Gramdan the whole village will become one family. Bhoodan was impelled by compassion, whereas Gramdan has, in addition to compassion, the idea of Samyayog behind it.



I am a mendicant. I attach little value to money. Even organisation has no value in my eyes. What then do I value? I value thoughts and ideas.



The compassion I feel is not for individuals but for society. I believe that when the compassion expands to embrace the whole creation, it acquires depth and serenity which is not to be found in the manifestation of shallow love. Still waters run deep.



I have autographed millions of copies of the '**Talks on the Gita**' published in several languages.



Mangru, a half-clad labourer, insisted on donating five decimals (one-twentieth of an acre) out of half an acre of land he owned.

Ramcharan, a blind man, came to our camp at 11 p.m. in the night and went off after submitting the declaration of land-gift. It was as if Lord Rama's *charans* (feet) had come to bless me.

I often turn down small donations of land from big landlords, but affectionately accept such donations from small landholders. Once a big landlord offered two acres of land, which I turned down. But at the same time I gladly accepted ten biswas (30% of an acre) from a poor farmer. The landlord then realized his mistake and corrected it by giving the *Daridranarayan* (God in the form of the poor) his due.

Many of the poor and the destitute have donated with devotion a fraction of whatever little they possessed. For me, it is a saga of unforgettable devotion. This yajna has motivated the poor for their emancipation while urging the rich to purify themselves and renounce ownership rights.

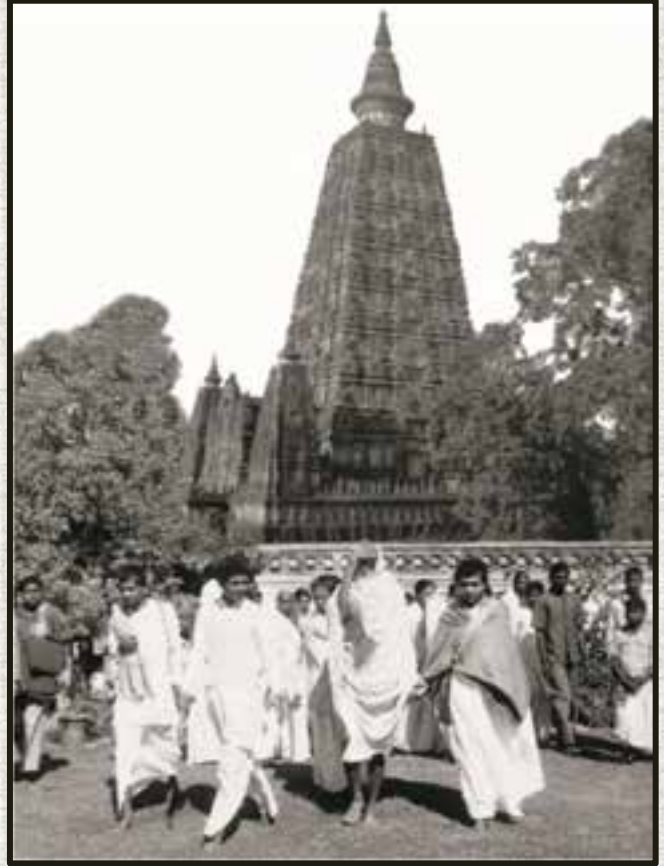


In the initial stages of Bhoodan I would go from house to house. I worked for twelve hours daily during the Telangana tour. I would walk for three to four hours and talk for eight to ten hours. I would take a round of the village, have meetings, hold discussions with the workers. The whole day I would be busy. On an average I received gifts of 50 to 60 acres of land per day there - - - In Bihar, I received about 300,000 declarations of gift. But I hardly did anything myself. I would just give talks every morning and evening. Sometimes there would be meetings with the workers. There was nothing else but the 'walking seminar'. I would neither go from house to house nor ask for gifts myself. The workers did everything.

Spinning wheel is a symbol of non-violence, a symbol of the dignity of labour, a symbol of self-sufficiency and self-reliance, a symbol of identification with the poor. What khadi seeks is social transformation and establishment of a co-operative commonwealth in the world.



This weak yarn is the yarn of love that binds us with the world. It is a vote for the Sarvodaya ideology. Spinning is a beautiful form of worship for all the people in the nation.



Vinobaji at the Bodhgaya temple

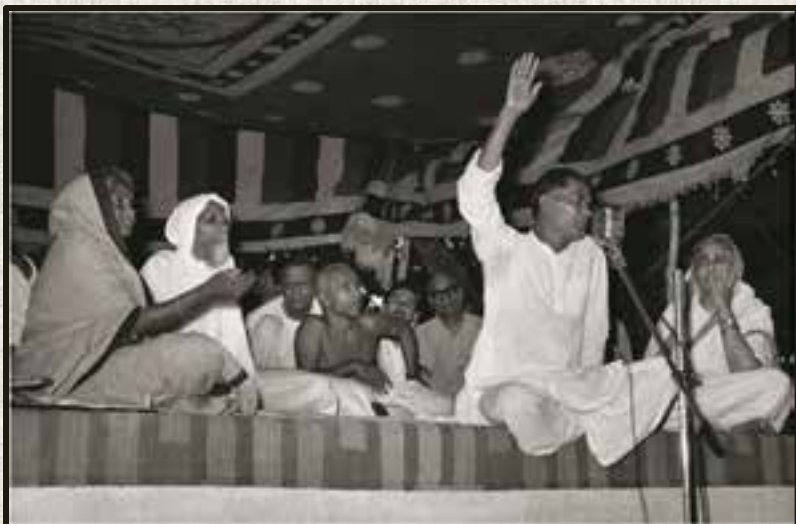
Research should go on in the field of spirituality too; otherwise, progress would reach a dead end. Mind should be receptive to new thoughts. We should, of course, be firm on certain basic values, but for the rest our mind should be open. To the extent we could achieve this would we advance towards harmony and synthesis.

The compassion that Lord Buddha taught to the people was extraordinary. He had the vision that compassion is impossible unless craving and hatred die out.

Indian culture and life have developed through the process of synthesis. I have therefore established *Samanvaya Ashram* at this place associated with Lord Buddha. I expect the Ashram to undertake study of the various schools of thought along with experiments in practical living. We want to bring about here synthesis of philosophy and life, of *Vedanta*—that is, Truth—and non-violence.



I often say in a lighter vein that I rarely get an opportunity to have a look at my face in the mirror. It is not, of course, necessary. I see myself in all the splendour in all the faces before me.



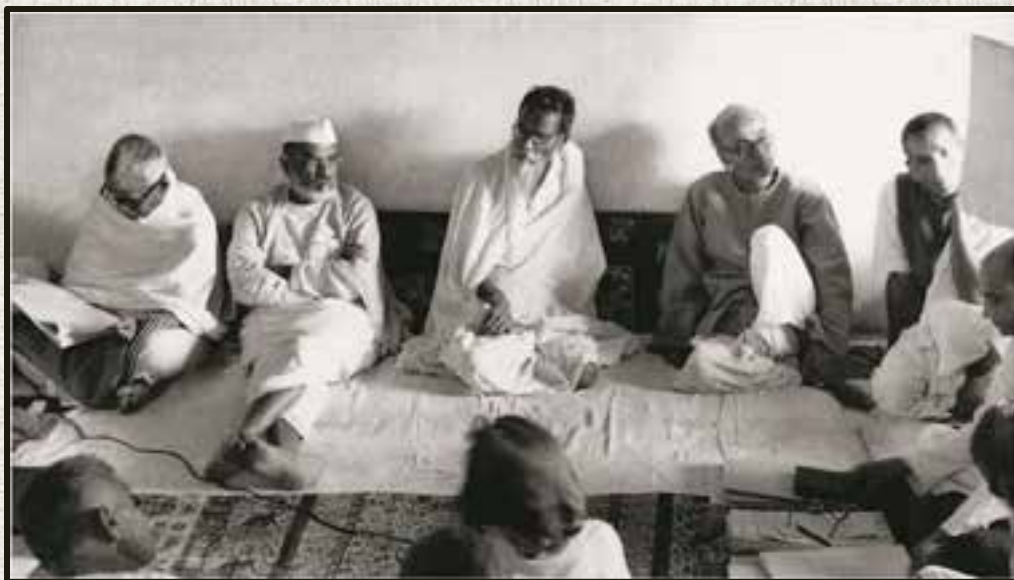
Jayaprakash Narayan declaring his resolve of 'Jeevandan' (dedicating the entire life for this cause). Also seen on the dais are Shri Aryanayakam, Ashadevi, Shankakrao Dev, Swami Ramanandtirtha, Rameshwari Nehru etc.



When Jayaprakashji declared his *Jeevandan*, it set me thinking. I wrote him a letter: 'Shri Jayaprakashji, in response to your appeal I hereby dedicate my life to the non-violent revolution which has Bhoodan-yajna as its foundation and leading role of the village industries.'

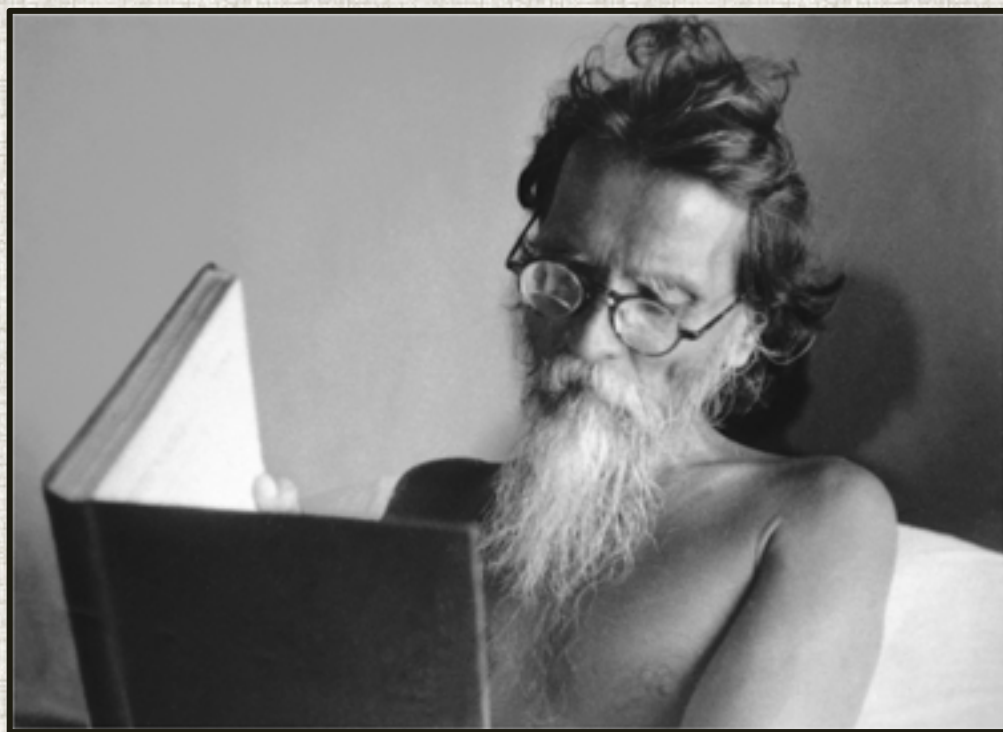


Only those workers who have the spirit of renunciation as well as the revolutionary spirit would continue to work in this movement. They would not, if they lack one or the other.



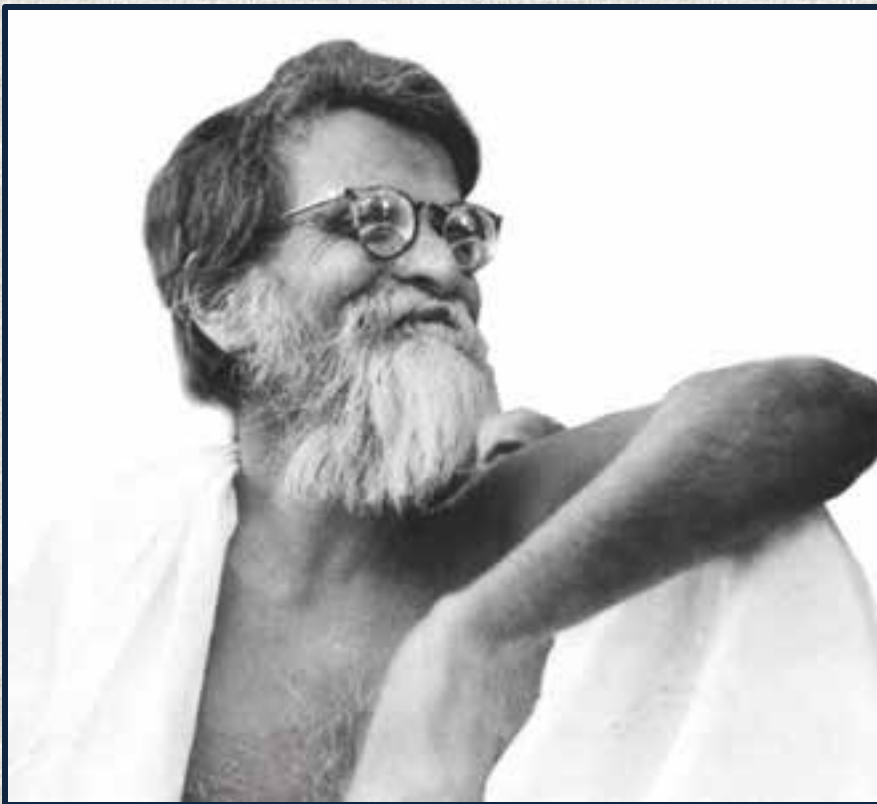
With Shankarrao Dev, J. C. Kumarappa, Dharendra Majumdar etc.

Today two powers are operating: the power of violence and the power of the state. We seek a third power—power of the people which will be opposed to the power of violence and will be different from the power of the state. That power will have to be created.



One who is always engaged in studies will be ever fresh. He will always have new insights, new ideas. He will never grow old. As his body gets worn out his memory and power of thinking go on brightening.

Lord Buddha had said that just as the body remains clean when we bathe every day and the house remains clean when we sweep it daily, the mind remains clean when we study every day.



I am constantly living in the presence of God. I do not feel that it is on my own strength that I am carrying out this walking mission for *Bhoodan*.



At Jagannathpuri, we had gone to the temple of Lord Jagannath with hearts full of devotion. But we had to return from its gate. We had a French sister with us, who was not allowed to enter the shrine. And it would have been irreligious for me to enter the temple without her. I had said at that time that I had no ill feeling for those who refused us entry. They were victims of the way their minds had been conditioned. But this is an unfortunate incident for our country and for our religion.



Tribals in Koraput attending a meeting



Land distribution—giving the title deed of land to a tribal

Today, we have standing before us the hungry Lord. He milks the cows, but does not get milk to drink. He works in the orchard, but cannot taste the fruits. He works in the wheat fields, but remains hungry. He has no roof over his head. Such a Lord is making fervent appeals to us for food and clothes.



Land distribution



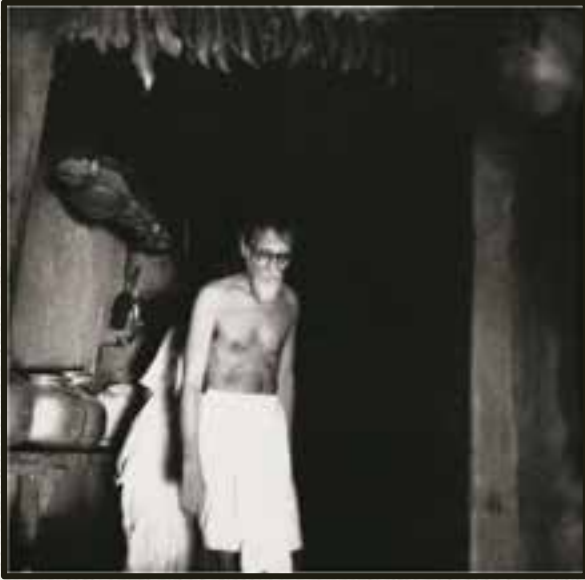
In the Konark temple



The walking pilgrimage used to start at 4 a.m., when it would be pitch dark outside, with the chanting of the Lord's Names

God has created the beautiful darkness which enables us to experience contentment, joy and peace. We are able to see the bright stars in the sky. But people have set even the darkness on fire.





In a hut in Koraput where there would be darkness at noon.



Meeting and a campsite made of twigs and branches in a tribal hamlet in Koraput

We have a tradition of putting a body of thought in a few aphorisms, to serve as a treasure house for students. One can then ruminate over them constantly. I had been thinking for a long time of composing Sanskrit aphorisms on the 'Talks on the Gita'.

In the course of our Bhoodan pilgrimage in Orissa we had to trek through dense forests for quite a few months. The solitude and the nature around provided an ideal setting for fulfilling that desire, and 108 Samyasutras were composed.

These aphorisms have taken shape after deep reflection. They can be likened to the Yogasutras of Patanjali. They are based on the 'Talks on the Gita'; however, they can be treated as independent aphorisms and used as such for reflection, as they convey a much wider meaning.



We have to travel on foot if we want to identify ourselves with the people. There is no other way - - - When I travel on foot, the people trust me and talk to me unreservedly. They feel that I am one of their own.

Beating the drum taken from the tribals who had come to welcome him



Today we had to cross the river through chest-high water. Was it a pleasant experience for the body? Had it been my personal work, I would have thought of postponing it. But it is social work; and so has to be done without break. All these workers who are walking on and on even in the rains are working with a sense of social responsibility.

Today's trek was especially memorable. It was raining throughout the last night. We had to cross rivers and streams nineteen times.



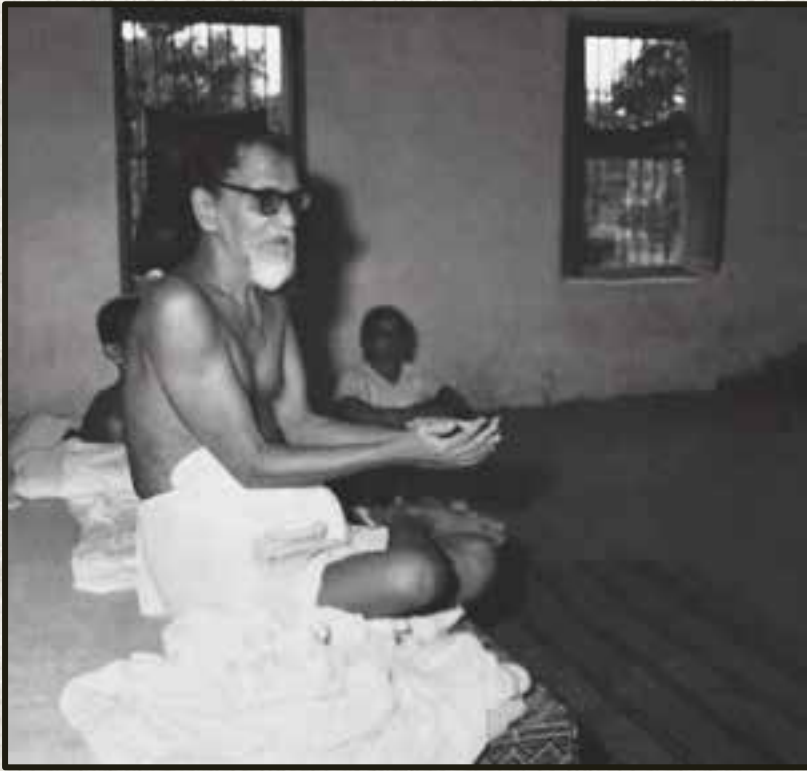
As the prayer time approaches, I feel a hunger for the prayer.

I often liken prayer to bath, meals and sleep. Bath cleans the body, whereas prayer cleanses the mind. The body is nourished by food, whereas the mind is nourished by prayer. Sleep gives rest to the body and rejuvenates it, whereas prayer provides rest to the mind and rejuvenates it spiritually.



One will have a bright intellect and a sharp memory if one's life is pure. And purity of food is one of the means for purifying life. If food is clean and pure, the mind remains happy and contented.

I have ulcers in my stomach. I have a mantra for it 'No hurry, no worry'. I have added to it the words 'Hari Hari' —
(Vinobaji kept the disease under control by living on milk and milk products.)



Some people object to the use of the word '*dan*'. Shankaracharya has defined '*dan*' as '*samvibhag*'—proper and uniform distribution. It means equality in distribution. '*Dan*' is an invariable obligation.



What I really seek through this work is to arouse the divinity that lies dormant in human beings.

One can have the vision of the Lord in three forms: in the form of the masses, in the form of the vast creation, and in the form of the divine element dwelling within us. All the three together give the vision in totality.



People say that *Baba* (Vinoba) is always presenting new thoughts. From where do these words and ideas come? They come from the sky. The word is an attribute of the sky. When one roams under the open sky, new words flash in one's mind.

I always receive nourishment from the sky.

If one wants to experiment with Truth, if one wants to search for ways and means to make non-violence effective, one should roam in the open, under the canopy of the sky. The Vedas have decreed us to walk on, as one who walks on lives in *Kritayuga* (the golden age).

Only experience can show how enchanting walking is. To a contemplative man, walking is even better than circumambulation of a temple.



Walking pilgrimage in Chennai. Also seen in the picture are K. Kamaraj, Chief Minister of the state and Shri Aryanayakam.

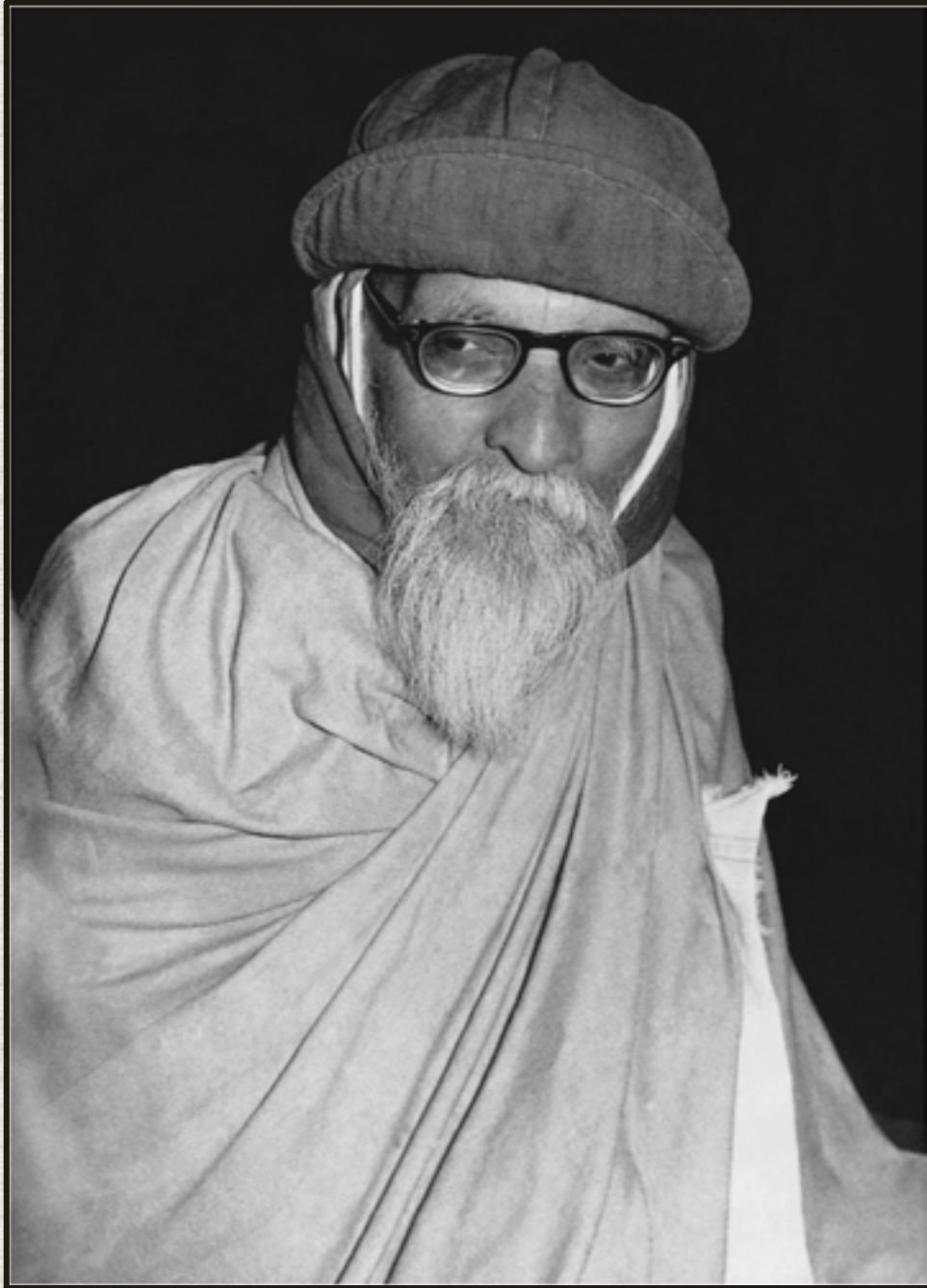


The walking tour reached Kanyakumari. We went to the seashore as the sun was rising, and watched the sea bathing goddess Kanyakumari's feet. I felt the touch of the sea water, I saw the glory of the sun, I bowed before the goddess Kanyakumari in my mind, and I renewed the pledge that I had already taken: 'This body will go on working ceaselessly until such time as the political freedom of India gets transformed into the freedom of every village community which then begins to govern itself.'



At Kanyakumari, where three oceans meet

The sea is roaring majestically all the time; as if chanting ॐ ! ॐ ! ॐ !
(Om.Om,Om)—reminding one of the Gita's exhortation - मामनुस्मर युध्य च
(Remember Me and fight on).



Supreme commander of Shanti-Sena

From Tamilnadu the walking mission went on to Kerala. The establishment of *Shanti-Sena* (Peace Army) was the most noteworthy event in the Kerala tour. *Bhoodan* had already emerged as a vehicle for the propagation of non-violence in society. I thought that time was now ripe for the establishment of a peace army consisting of peace soldiers, one for every five thousand of the population. These soldiers would be thoughtful and active servants of society. Their normal work will be to serve society in such a way that any outbreak of violence will be averted. However, in case the peace does get disturbed, their job in such emergencies will be to restore it.



We walked on chanting the verses in *Samaveda* — 'The spring is lovely, the summer is lovely, the rainy season is lovely ...'



While walking in a downpour, I would chant aloud the *Vedic* verse wherein the sage prays for a heavy downpour as a sign of the grace of God. 'Let there be no obstacle hindering our pace. Let our will-power increase a thousand times.' My experience has affirmed this.

The Veda has decreed us to walk on and on — *Charaiveti Charaiveti*. It has been said that if you sit still, your fortune too will stand still; but if you start walking, fortune will smile on you.



*Be it snowfall, the scorching summer, or incessant rains
Nothing can stop his feet
No, the saint just cannot rest
for it is God's work that he has to carry on*



Crossing the backwaters on foot



Crossing the backwaters by boat (in Kerala)



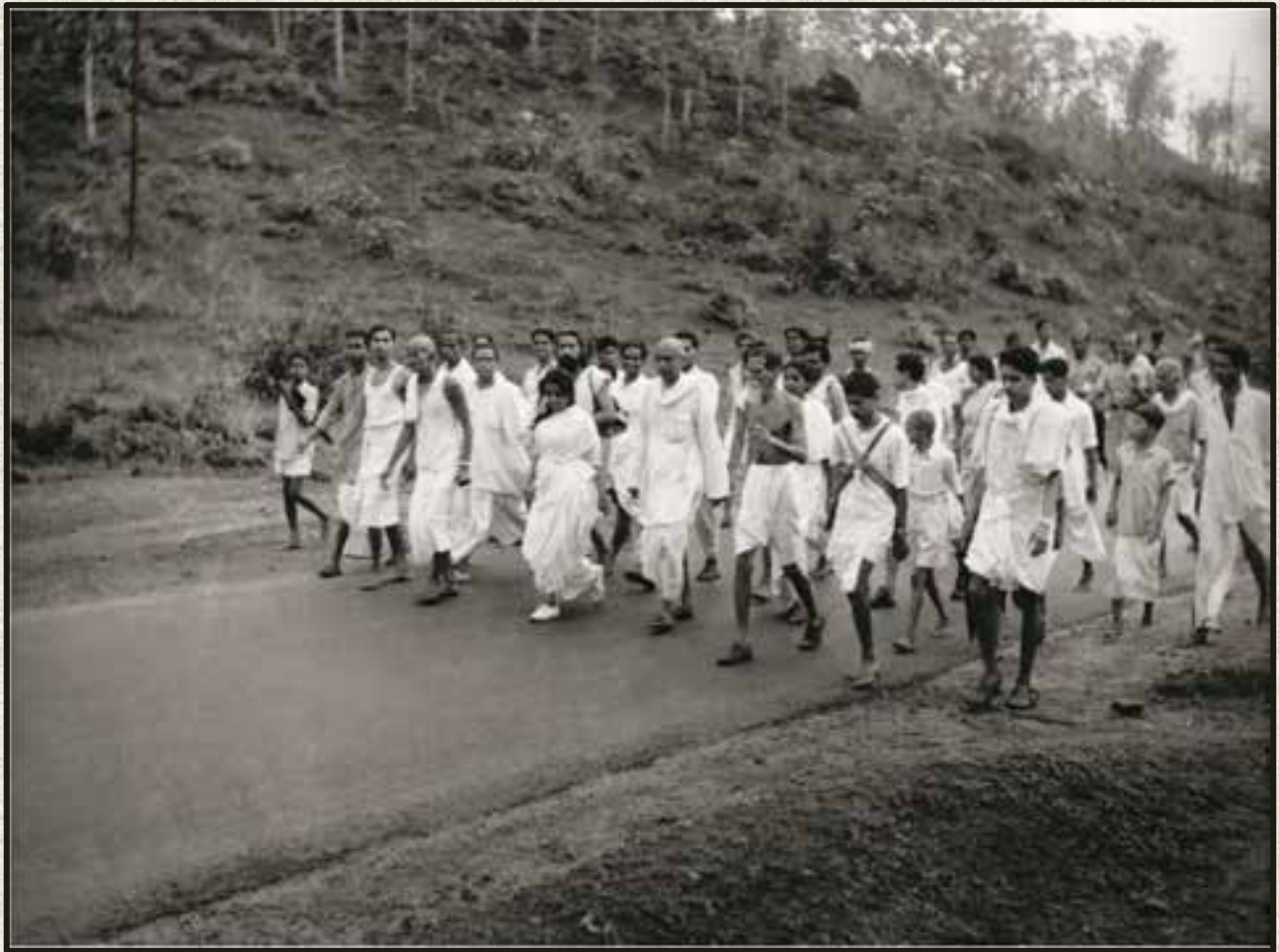
Workers dancing and singing with joy on the dais at the Kaladi (Kerala) Sarvodaya Conference (1957) as it pours heavily outside.



An All-Party Gramdan Conference took place at Yelwal (September 21st and 22nd, 1957). It unanimously supported the idea of Gramdan.

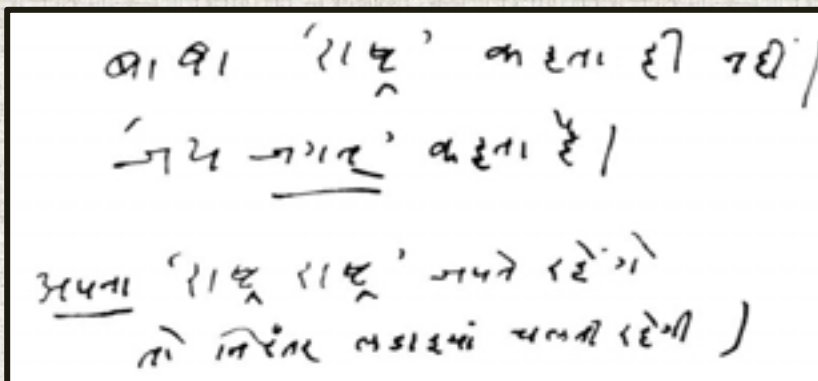
I have met a lot of good men, noble men, great men in the world. But when I think of Vinoba, I doubt whether such a man exists elsewhere in the world. His work and his pilgrimage has had a great influence on the head and heart of India. It is very difficult to assess the contribution of such a man - - - Vinobaji would certainly have a place of honour in any authentic history of India.

— Jawaharlal Nehru

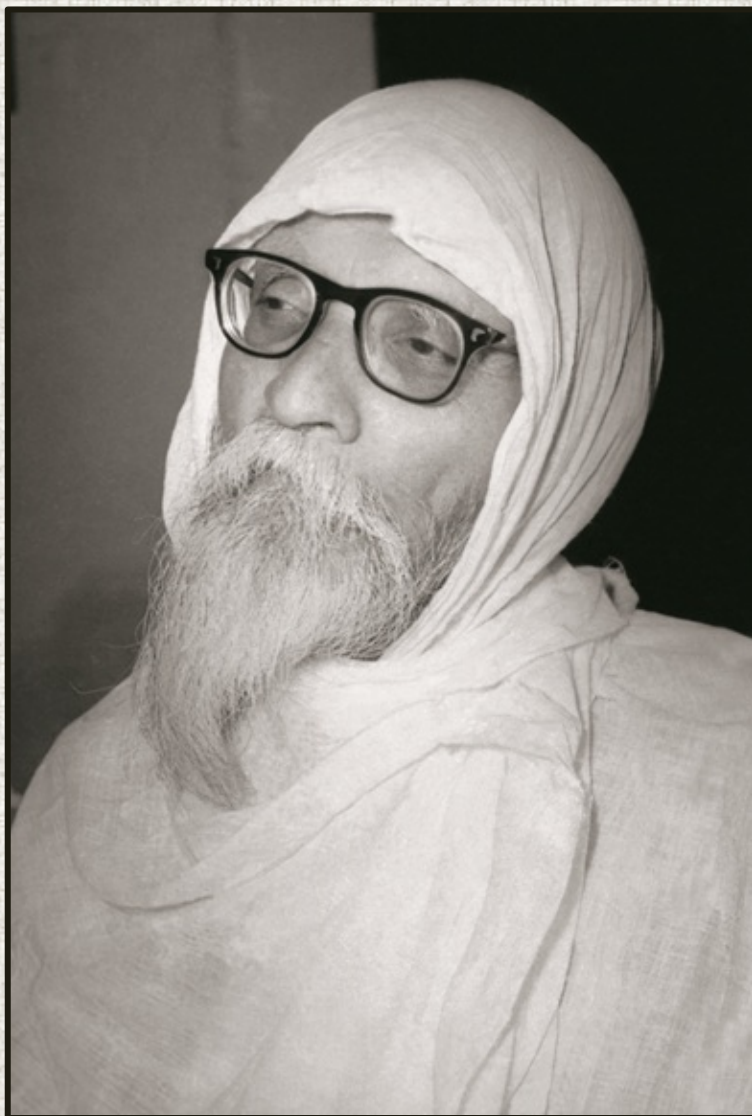


Walking seminar : With Dada Dharmadhikari, Vimla Thakar etc.

My first step was to say, give some land. Then I began to ask for one-sixth of the land. After that I said to people, see to it that no one in your village is without land. Next, I began to tell them that there should not be private ownership of land and put forward the concept of *Gramdan*. I preached that like air, water and sunlight, land too is for everyone. Then I began to talk about village *swaraj* (self-government). I also propounded *Sampattidan*, *Shanti-Sena*, *Sarvodaya-patra* etc.



In Karnataka I began using a new mantra: '*Jai Jagat*' (Victory to the world) (November 1, 1957). Fifteen years earlier we had begun to use the slogan '*Jai Hind*' (Victory to India). Now we had moved on to '*Jai Jagat*'. All over the world, the people's outlook is advancing rapidly. Boundaries between different countries are going to be erased gradually. Possibility of the world becoming a single united family is increasing.



Government keeps army; people have consented to it. We too need people's approval for the cause of non-violence. For this purpose I have put forward the idea of *Sarvodaya-patra* (January 1, 1958). Let every household have a pot and drop handful of grain in it daily; and let the hand be the little hand of the youngest child in the family. The child will thereby learn to give something to society. It will also learn to keep away from violence as it knows that the grain is being given for the sake of peace—for the maintenance of *Shanti-Sena*. Thus *Sarvodaya-patra* has a triple purpose: 1. It is a pledge to abstain from taking part in violent activities, 2. It is a vote for non-violent social order, 3. It is to inculcate the sense of social obligation in the children.

The day I hit upon this idea of *Sarvodaya-patra*, I felt as though I had become a *rishi*! Behind this idea there is, it seems to me, a true vision.



Sarvodaya — the ideology we have adopted— claims to bring about change of heart in the people. We have therefore to delve deeper than the saints of the past. Those saints primarily sought self-purification; and rendered some such service to the society as could be done in normal course. But we talk of social transformation, of transformation of the entire life, of creating a new man; so we have to delve deep into the realm of spirituality.

I have always been contemplative by nature. And as the work (the Sarvodaya Movement) is spreading in the country, this trait is getting more and more strengthened. It is God's work, and will be done by Him. We are just His instruments.

Jai Jagat is our *mantra*. *Gramdan* is our technique. World peace is our goal.



In Pandharpur Sarvodaya Conference



Our pilgrimage of love went on and on, going from one region to another — from the land of Tulsidas and Kabir to the land of Buddha and Mahavir to the land of Chaitanya and Jagannath, and then to the land of Shankara and Ramanuja and Basaveshwar, and finally I have come to the land of Jnaneshwar. I have now reached Pandharpur.

I have no words to express what I felt as I stood before the image of Lord Vithoba. Tears continued to roll down my cheeks for a long time as I did not see there a stone image; what I saw there was the Lord Himself.

I had with me two sisters — one Muslim and one Christian. This is an unprecedented event. It revealed the true nature of Hinduism.

Kaka Kalelkar has given us a *mantra* :
'A-sarkari asar-kari' (Non-governmental work is effective).

Someone said, "Vinoba does not know the ways of the world." Kakasaheb replied, "Yes; it is true. But that is because he does not attach any importance to the ways of the world."





Visit to Dhule jail (1958) where the 'Talks on the Gita' were delivered



Climbing up the Panhala fort



With the Gandhians in Gujrat — Jugatrambhai, Babalbhai, Surendraji, Kanubhai etc.



Bathing in the open during the walking tour — Jayaprakash Narayan and Ravishankar Maharaj



In Vedchhi Ashram



The farewell meeting in Gujarat

The *Veda* says that the Lord has thousands of heads, thousands of hands, thousands of feet — सहस्रशीर्षा पुरुषः सहस्राक्षः सहस्रपाद् । I am daily having this vision of the Lord. That vision nurtures me. That has enabled me to work with this body even in adverse circumstances.



Had I not tested my body rigorously, had I not developed the capacity for enduring cold, heat, rains, storm etc., I would not have been able to sustain myself in this *Bhoodan pilgrimage*.



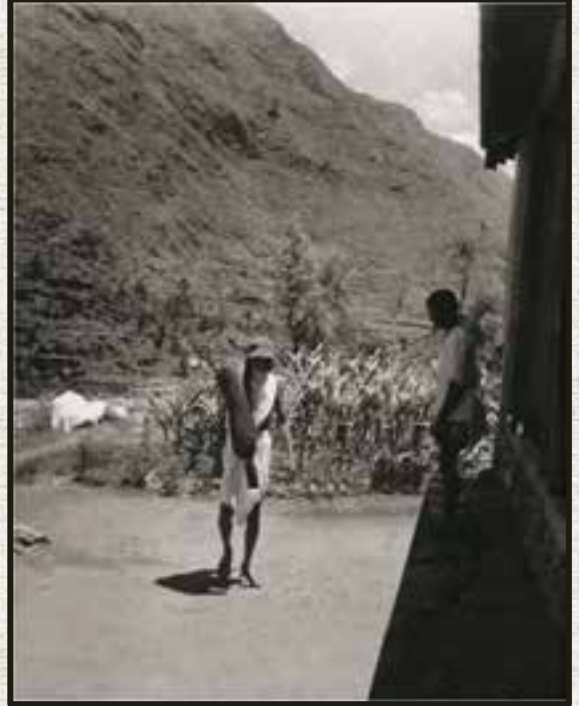
A rally of Shanti-Sena



Entering Sikar (Rajasthan)



*This path is for the heroes - -
Where cowards don't dare tread*



*With luggage slung over the shoulder,
ready for the day's walk*



Walking on a railway track, in the absence of a road



In this age of science, religion and politics have become outdated. Science and spirituality will take their place. Spirituality will give direction to the progress in science.

Politics + Science = Total ruin

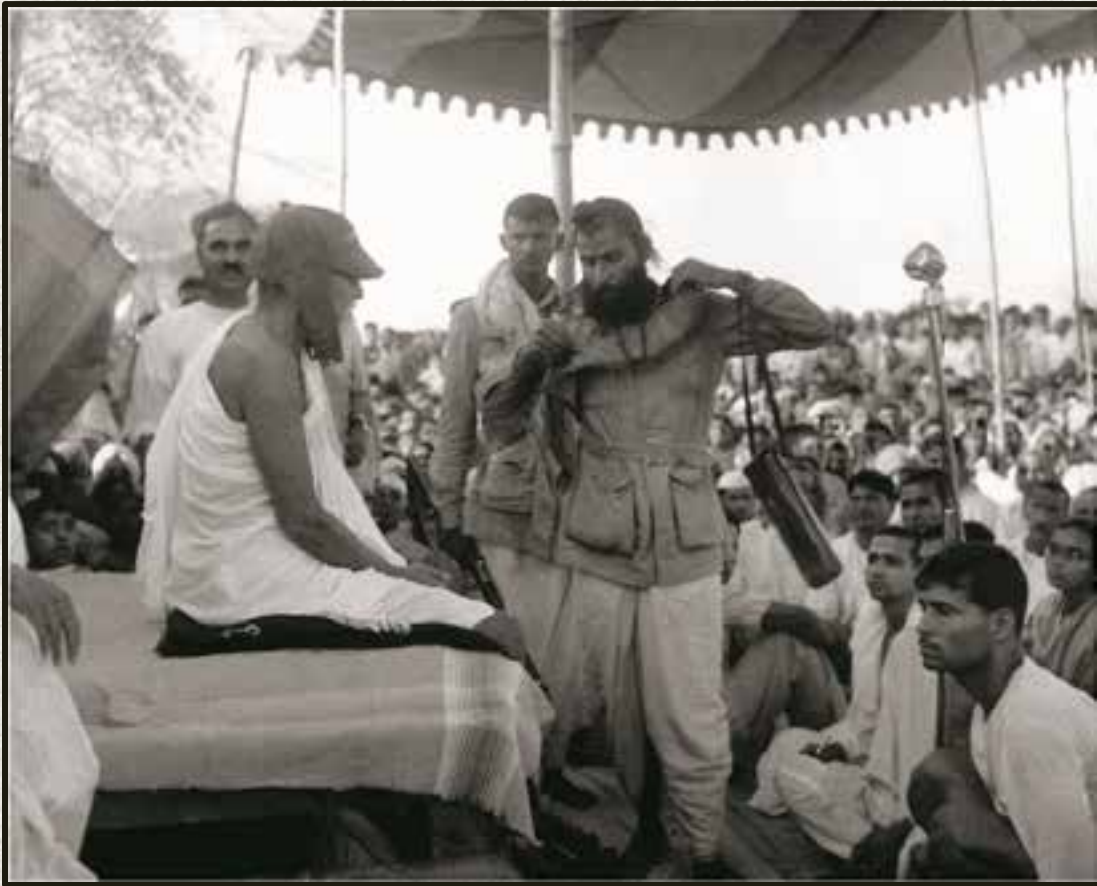
Science + Spirituality = Sarvodaya

In Kashmir, I have come to see, to hear and to love.

I have come here after crossing the Pir Panjal hills at this old age. It was the grace of God that made this possible. We were held up by rains and flood for six days at Mandi Rajpura. Nature's fury was daily taking a heavy toll of houses and human lives there.

A man came one day to give me land because his wife had told him to do so. She had seen a photograph in some newspaper which showed someone giving me a hand to help me over a difficult stretch of road. The picture made her feel that when a man is taking so much trouble to help the poor, it would not be right to refuse him land. In my view, the stature of that woman as a human being touched greater heights than the Pir Panjal which I had crossed at an altitude of 13500 feet!



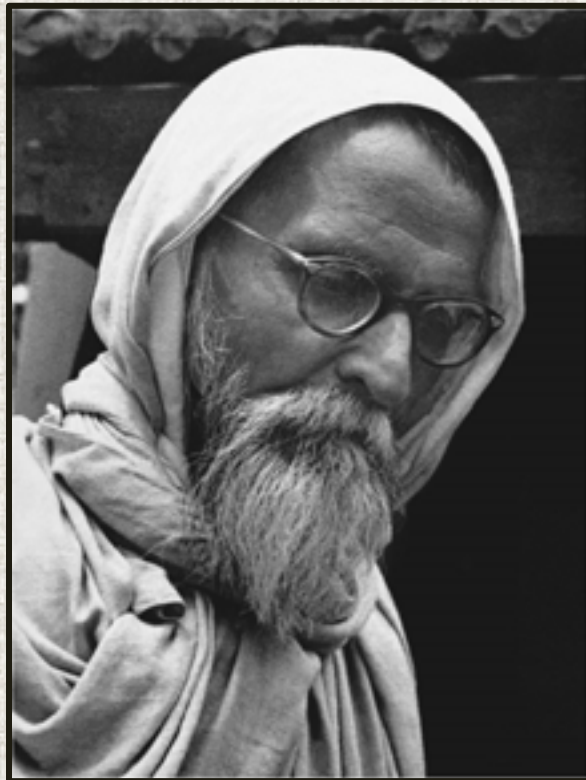


The surrender of dacoits in the Chambal ravines was totally unexpected. Those who had adopted dacoity as the means of their livelihood came to me with a feeling of repentance and abandoned their former ways. Twenty of them laid down their guns—some of them costly telescopic rifles—and surrendered themselves to me (May 19, 1960). It seems that God penetrated their hearts and brought about this miracle.

People ask, 'Have the hearts of these dacoits really changed?' In fact, it is my heart that has undergone transformation. I was very harsh by nature. But experiences during the *Bhoodan* pilgrimage made my heart tender and sensitive. These dacoits made me all the more tender-hearted.

I set up *Visarjan Ashram* at Indore (August 15, 1960). The purpose of this *ashram* is to perform *visarjan* (submergence) of out-dated values, and along with it *vi-sarjan* (re-emergence) of those living values which are suited to the new age.

In 1960 I spent five weeks at Indore. As I went round the city I saw filthy cinema posters in a number of places. There seemed to be no bounds to the dismay I felt at the sight of those filthy, offensive posters. I told the public there that their children were being given free and compulsory education in sensuality. I told the women in particular to rise against them, and not to put up with them for even a day longer; they should remove them, burn them. I appealed to them to take up the task of guarding the peace and character of this country.



Doing some ordinary work cannot be the purpose of this life; it can be nothing else than God-realisation. It is not for Bhoodan or Gramdan that I am working; I am working for Self-realisation.



Walking on the roof of the boat in the river Brahmaputra



The mammoth gathering to welcome Vinobaji on the banks of Brahmaputra



The brain of India is in the cities, but her heart is in villages. As long as we do not reach the people's heart, we would not be in a position to affect their thinking. That is why I am travelling on foot, avoiding the use of vehicles.



A public meeting in the downpour. Amalprabha Das is translating the speech.



It is raining; the Lord Himself is touching us by His thousands of hands. These sacred raindrops cause the crops grow, it is due to them that our life goes on. The rain teaches us equality. It pours over the fields of poor farmers as well as rich farmers. It does not even distinguish between soil, rocks, hills or sea. It knows no distinction; it loves all uniformly. It is a mark of God's grace.



Tribal women looking on with curiosity



People welcoming in their village

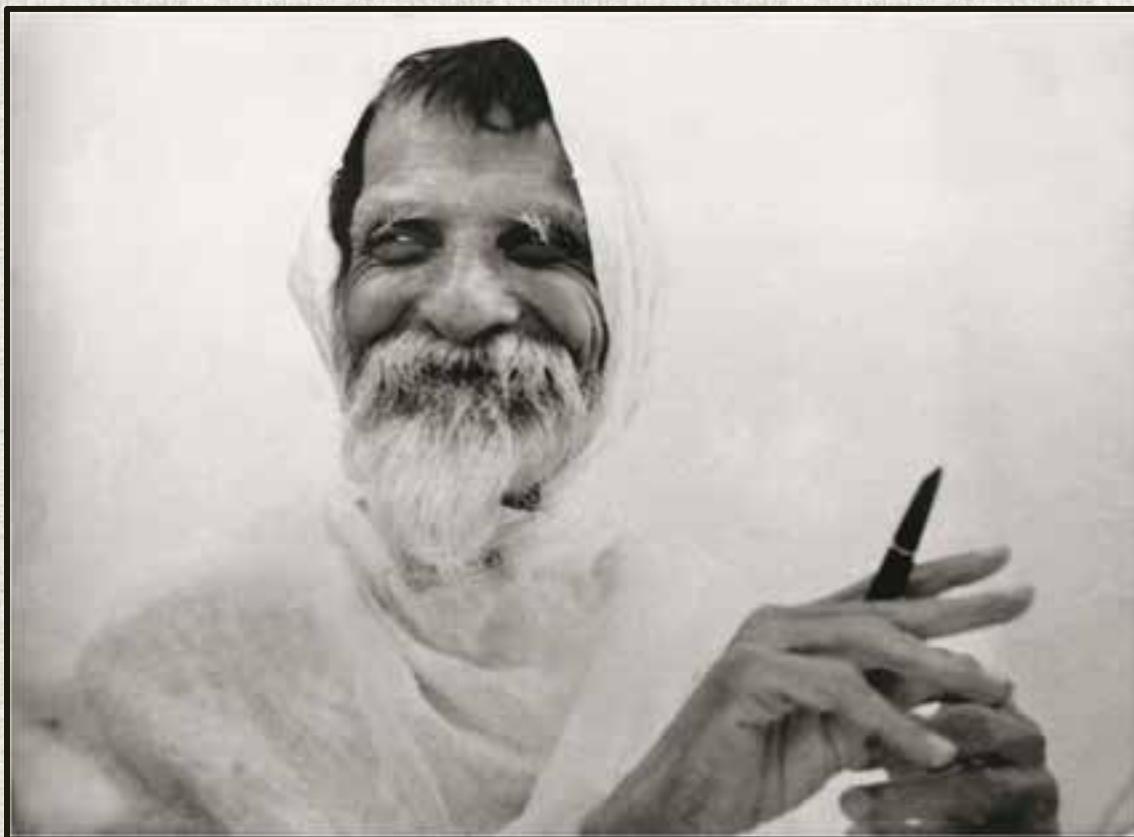


There is confluence of different cultures at the borders between different regions. Cultural centres or ashrams should be set up there. In this view I have set up *Maitri Ashram* on the NEFA (Arunachal)-Assam border (March 5, 1962). The only rule in this *ashram* is friendship (*maitri*), its only goal is friendship, its only programme is friendship. Friendship has always been a necessity; however, its need is particularly pressing in this age.

Every village should have a *gramsabha* (village assembly). It should look after the whole village like a mother. It will support the orphans. It will care for the children, the old men and women, the sick, the widows and the unemployed. It will not be a co-operative institution in the conventional sense of the term, although the element of co-operation will certainly be there in it. It will not wield coercive power; its power will be that of love. It will therefore work on the principle of consensus, not on the principle of majority.

The present *panchayat* system is faulty. *Panchayats* are plagued by the ingress of political parties because of the principle of majority. They are formed not through service, but through power struggles. Exploitation is inevitable in them because of the element of power. I have called them 'a decentralised scheme for exploitation' — exploitation being decentralised is more effective! *Panchayat* thus means efficient, effective, decentralised exploitation!





We are not attached to and proud of any particular country.

We do not insist on following any particular religion.

We are not tied to any sect or caste.

Roaming freely in the garden of noble thoughts in the whole world constitutes our study.

Assimilating noble thoughts and making them our own is our sacred duty.

Harmonising and synthesizing different characteristics and developing a global vision constitutes our ideological quest.

In Bengal I said, referring to Ramakrishna Paramhans, that from now on what is needed is collective rather than individual *samadhi* (a state of communion with the Lord). Ramakrishna Paramhans could not bear to touch money; I am following in his footsteps and seeking a way to free the whole of society from the bondage of money.





Walking through the floodwaters in Assam

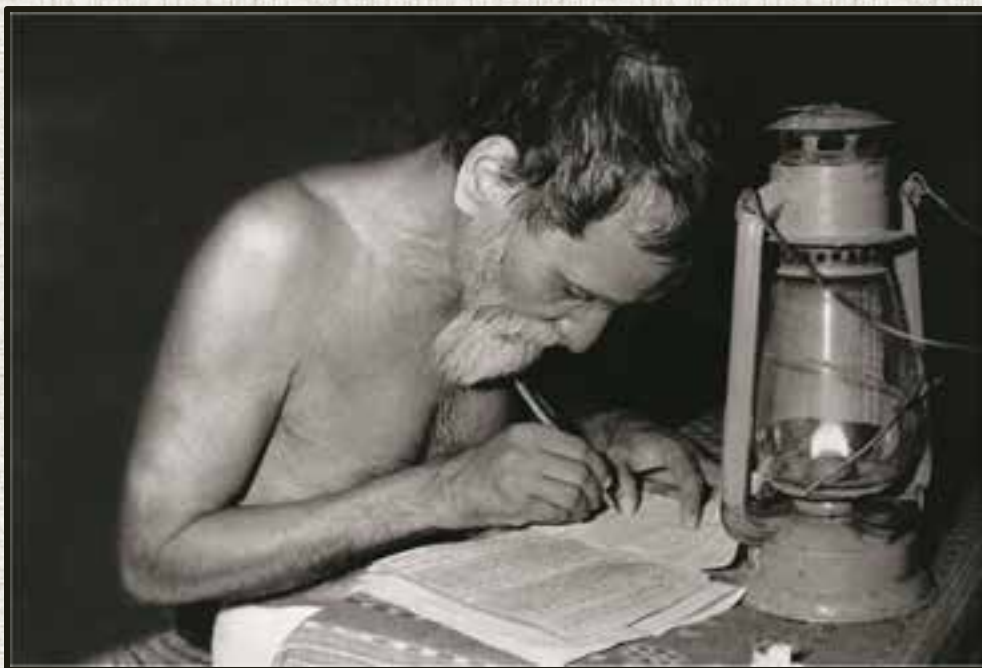


Travelling by a boat in Assam when the roads and the fields were inundated



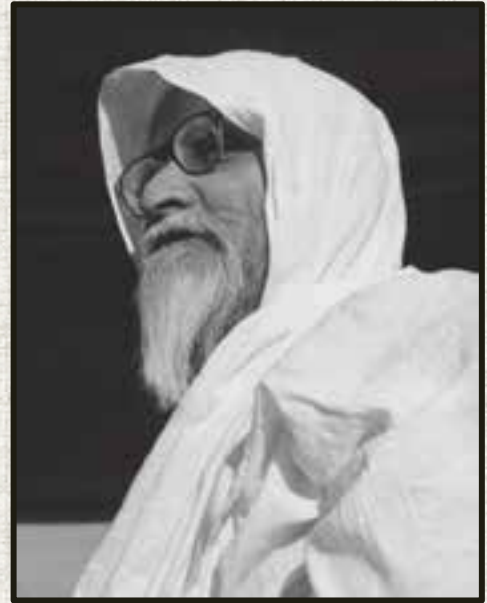
Entering East Pakistan

In East Pakistan (now Bangladesh) we travelled for sixteen days. On the very first day a Muslim gentleman came and offered land-gift. He gifted one acre out of four acres he owned. I touched his shoulders and said, 'I would pray to Allah for you.' Tears welled up in his eyes. This first gift was a sacred gift. Thereafter we got land-gifts every day - - - At my first two or three meetings people shouted '*Pakistan Zindabad*' (Long live Pakistan). '*Jai Jagat*', I responded, and gradually the phrase caught on there too.

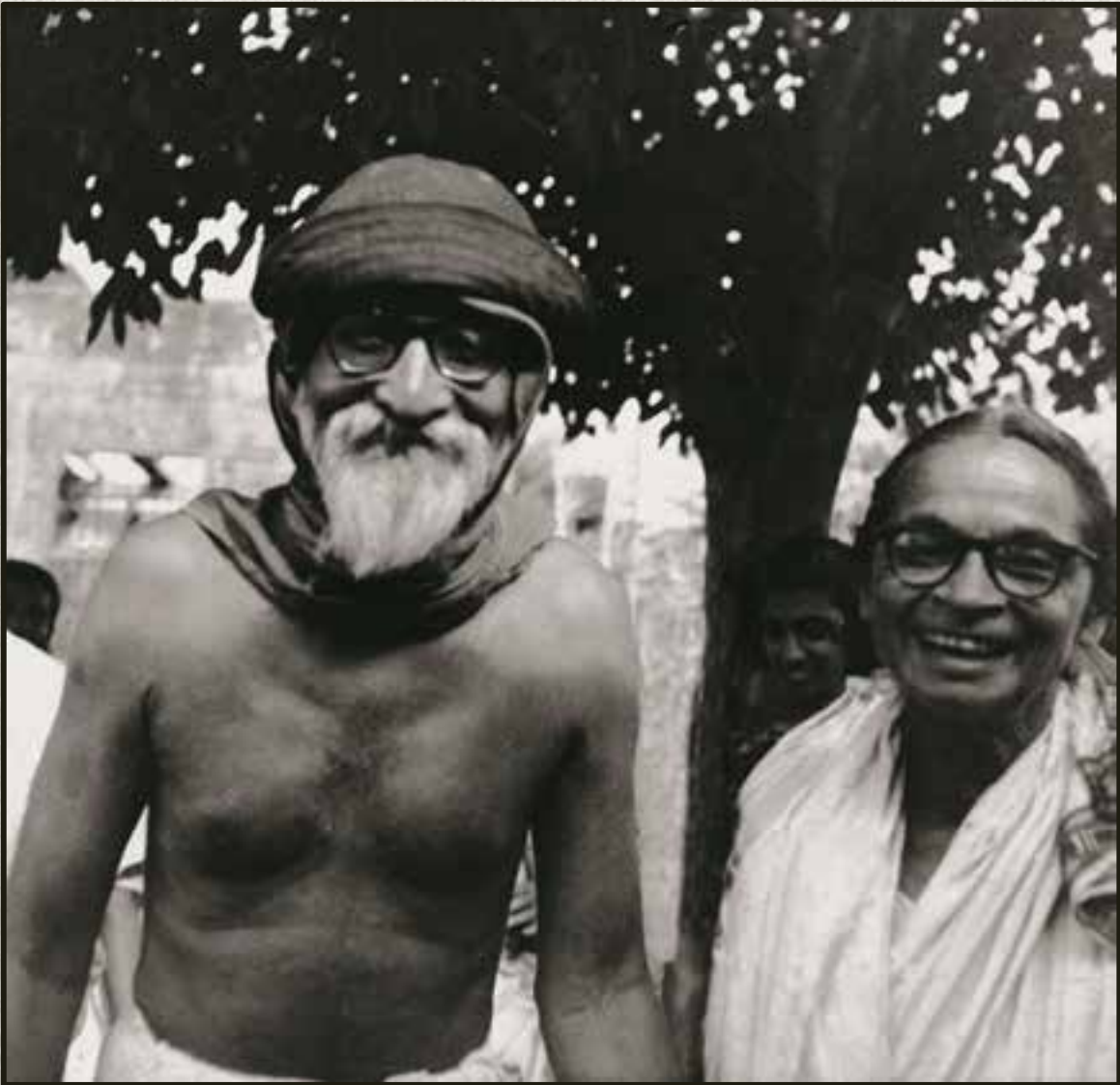


I have been a student all my life. I have never ceased to be one. Studying and teaching have always accompanied all my activities.

I do not look upon the people in front of me as men; for me they are images of the Lord. I feel that the Lord that resides in my heart has taken a variety of forms for me to behold.

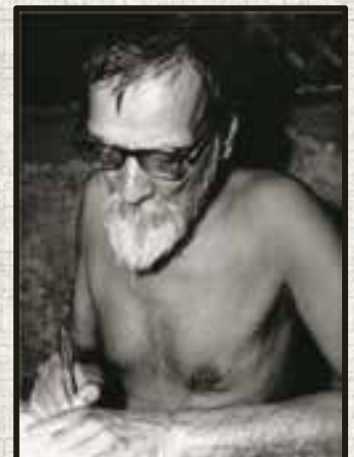


Here the holy river Ganga is meeting the ocean. This reminds one of the submergence of a devotee into divine consciousness. Just as Ganga merges into the ocean, the Self merges into the Supreme Self. I sat for some time in meditation overlooking the ocean and greatly enjoyed the experience. I had also meditated at Kanyakumari and at Pir Panjal in the Himalayas. How vast our country is! Our hearts should also become likewise.



Everyone has a right on us, but we should have a right on no one besides God. Once this is understood, man will be cheerful.

If adequate attention is not paid to the depth in thinking and studies, work becomes lifeless.





Now my feet do not remain steady. I often feel giddy. These feet have walked around 70,000 kms. They have walked on in hilly areas, in deserts, in all the seasons. Now these feet want to rest. What more can be expected of them?

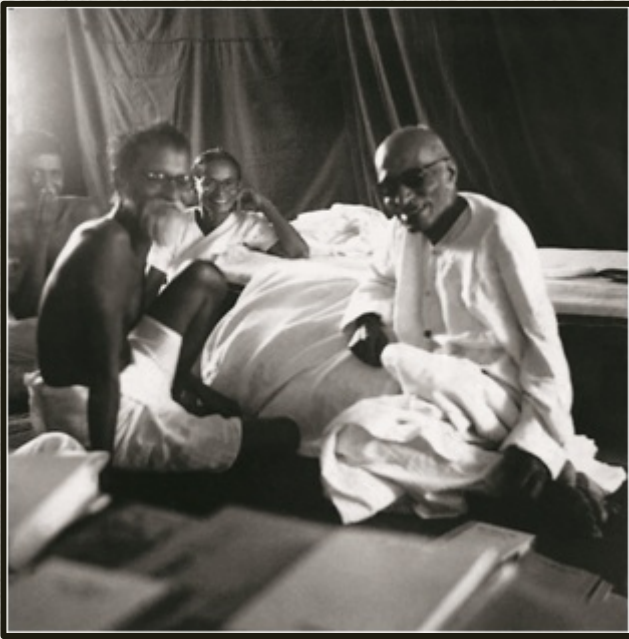
What I aim at is nothing less than Ram-rajya (Kingdom of God). I can speak in no smaller terms.



Going to Bihar by car for the Gramdan Toofan (typhoon) campaign (1965)



At the function to announce district-dan of Darbhanga district during the Toofan campaign. On both the sides of the stage are piles of the declarations of Gramdans from different sub-divisions of the district. These declarations had been brought by a truck.



With C. Rajgopalachari



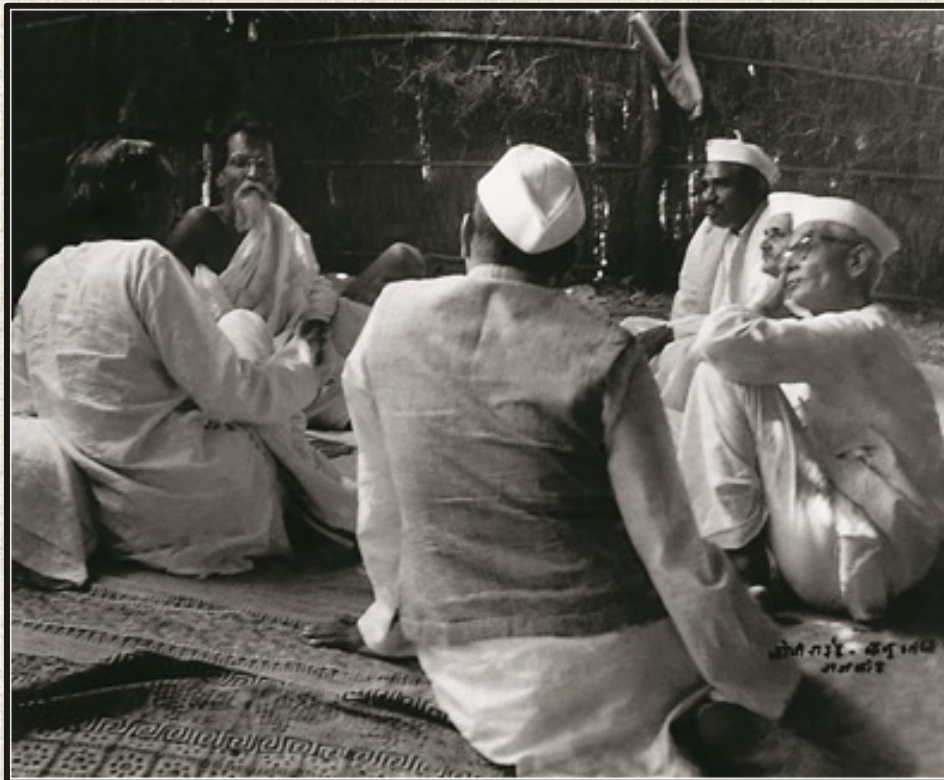
With Swami Kundrakudi of a Tamil mutt



With Swami Sharananandji and other religious figures



With Tukdoji Maharaj



*With J. B. Kripalani, Shriman Narayan, Haribhau Upadhyay,
Lal Bahadur Shastri and Jagjivan Ram*



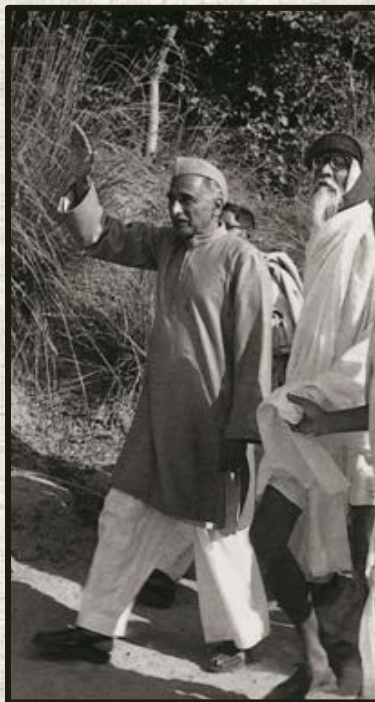
With Kaithan and Jagannathan



Cutting vegetables with Gopabandhu Choudhari of Odisha



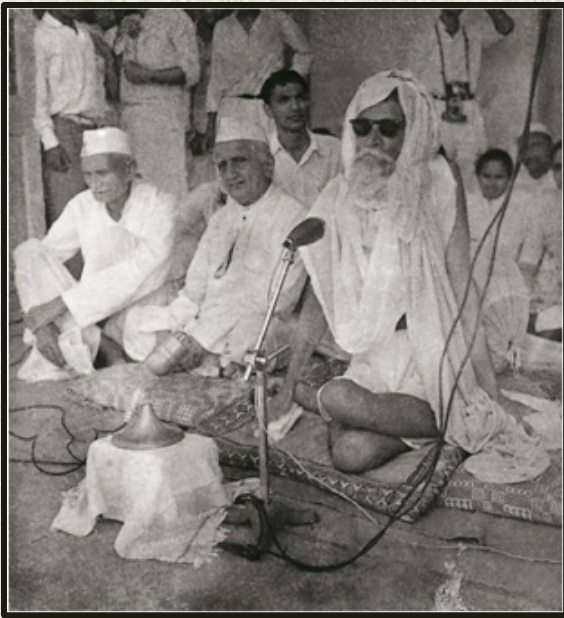
With Swami Ramdas at Kanangarh ashram



With Achyut Patwardhan



With Pandurang Shastri Athavale



With Pandit Satavalekar and Ravishankar Maharaj at a conference on the Vedas



Poet Dukhayal singing a Bhoodan song



Inauguration of Brahmavidya-Mandir at Kashi-ka-Bas (13-3-1959)



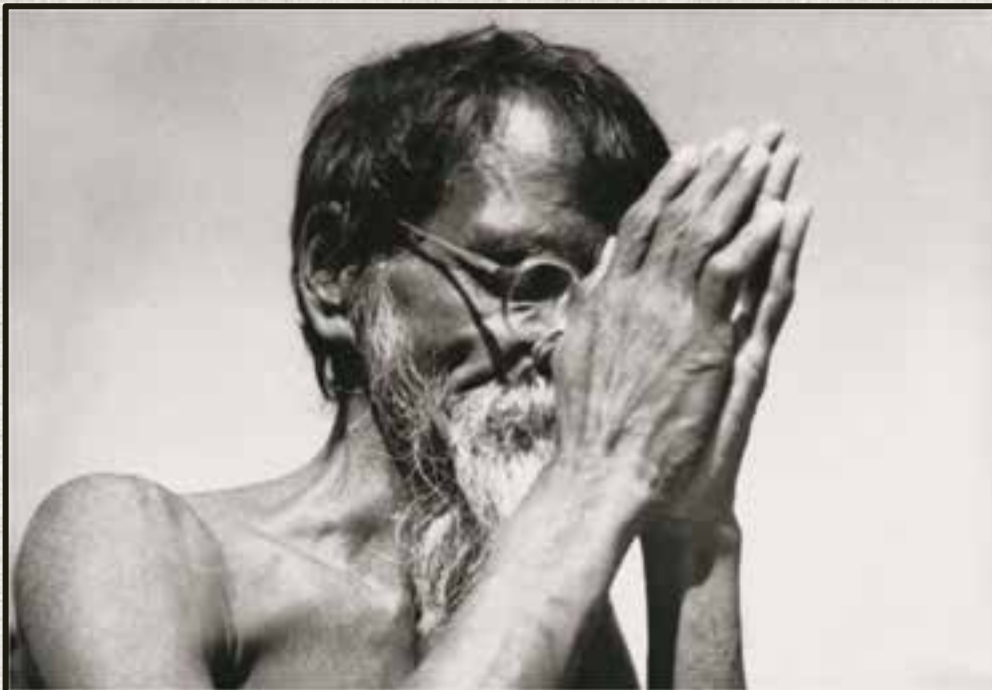
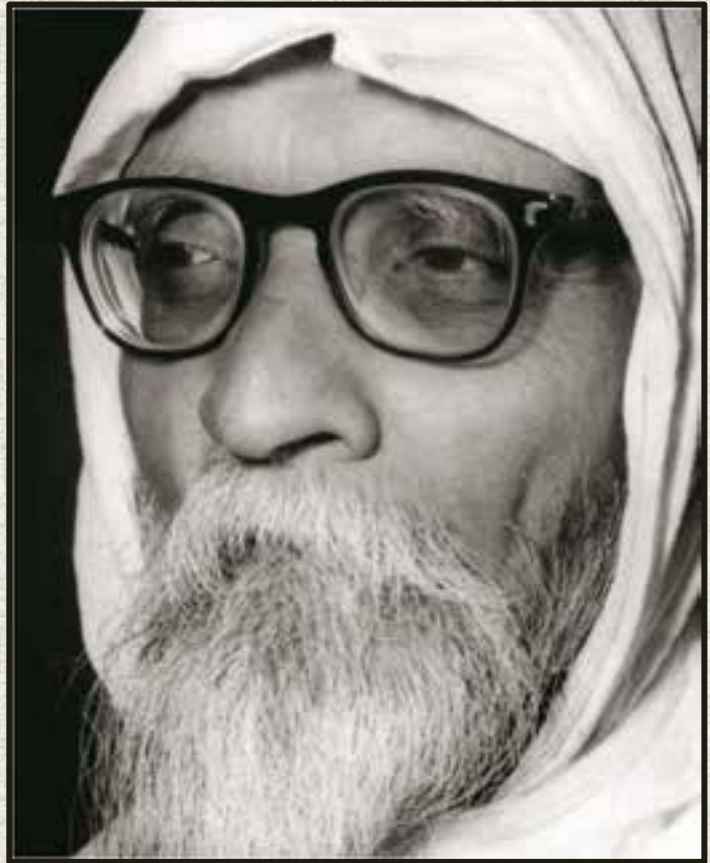
Sleep should be without worries, deep and dreamless. In dreamless sleep, thoughts keep on developing.

Before going to sleep, we should surrender to God whatever had been done during the day. That should be keenly examined, as perception of our faults and an earnest appeal to God to forgive must accompany the evening prayer.



Returning to Pavnar after the Toofan campaign

I cannot deny that there is an element of mysticism in me. So, while I am walking on the earth my mind is on a different plane. Had I not come to Gandhiji, I would perhaps have followed the way of the mystics, the way of meditation. But fascination for the Gita was there since childhood; and the Gita has said that the way of the meditation and that of the action are one and the same. I therefore realised the need for balance in life; and the contradictions within me were finally resolved in the company of Gandhiji. Since then, I have been following his way with exclusive concentration. But still there is something different within.



What I have got from the ancestors and the moderns, from those far and near, is indescribable. It is much more than what I could ever give. I do not feel that I am doing anything to repay their debt. There is therefore no other way than to salute the people with gratitude. I salute you all with devotion.

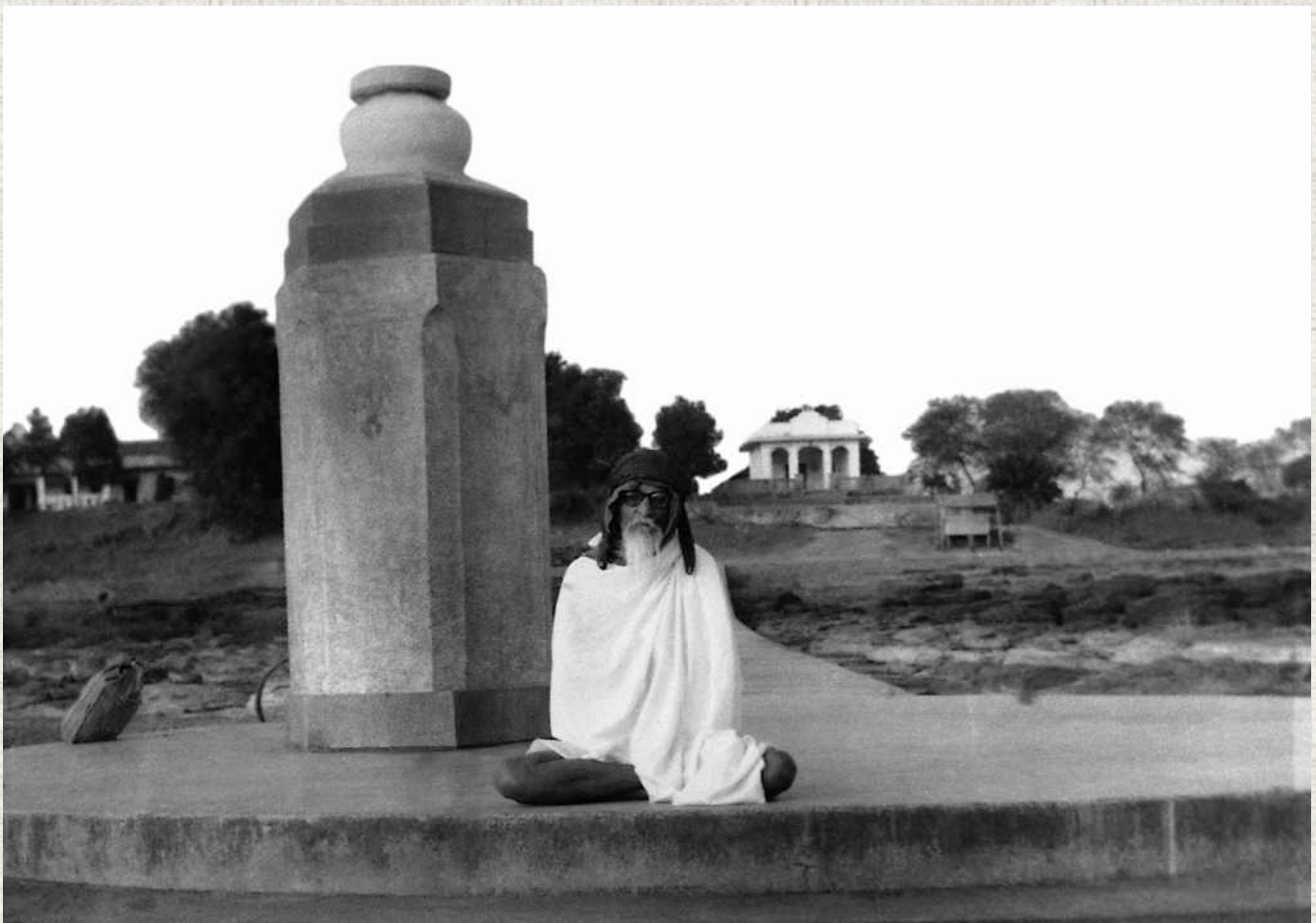


The name of this *ashram* is *Brahmagyda-Mandir*. It is a place for collective *sadhana* (spiritual pursuit) for *Brahmagyda* (science of God-realisation). Most of the residents here are women, but there are a few men also. All the work is done by the inmates. They spend some time in doing agricultural work. All share the work of cooking, scavenging and general cleanliness. Books on spiritual subjects and a monthly '*Maitri*' are published from here. The main features of this ashram are : 1. Collective *sadhana*, 2. Dignity and sanctity of labour, 3. Identification with others for meditation, study and devotion, 4. *Brahmacharya*.

So far, the science of *Brahmagyda* has been developed by men and so it tends to be one-sided. It needs to be revised and that work should be done by women. This *Brahmagyda-Mandir* is for the coming age. The coming age belongs to women. *Brahmagyda-Mandir* has been set up for them. Here the men may help them, but there will be no dependence on the men.

It is a place where everything should be done by women, but they should experience within that they are not the doers. If they do not feel so, they may become leaders, but they would be far from *Brahmagyda*. An experience of not being the doer is essential for *Brahmagyda*.

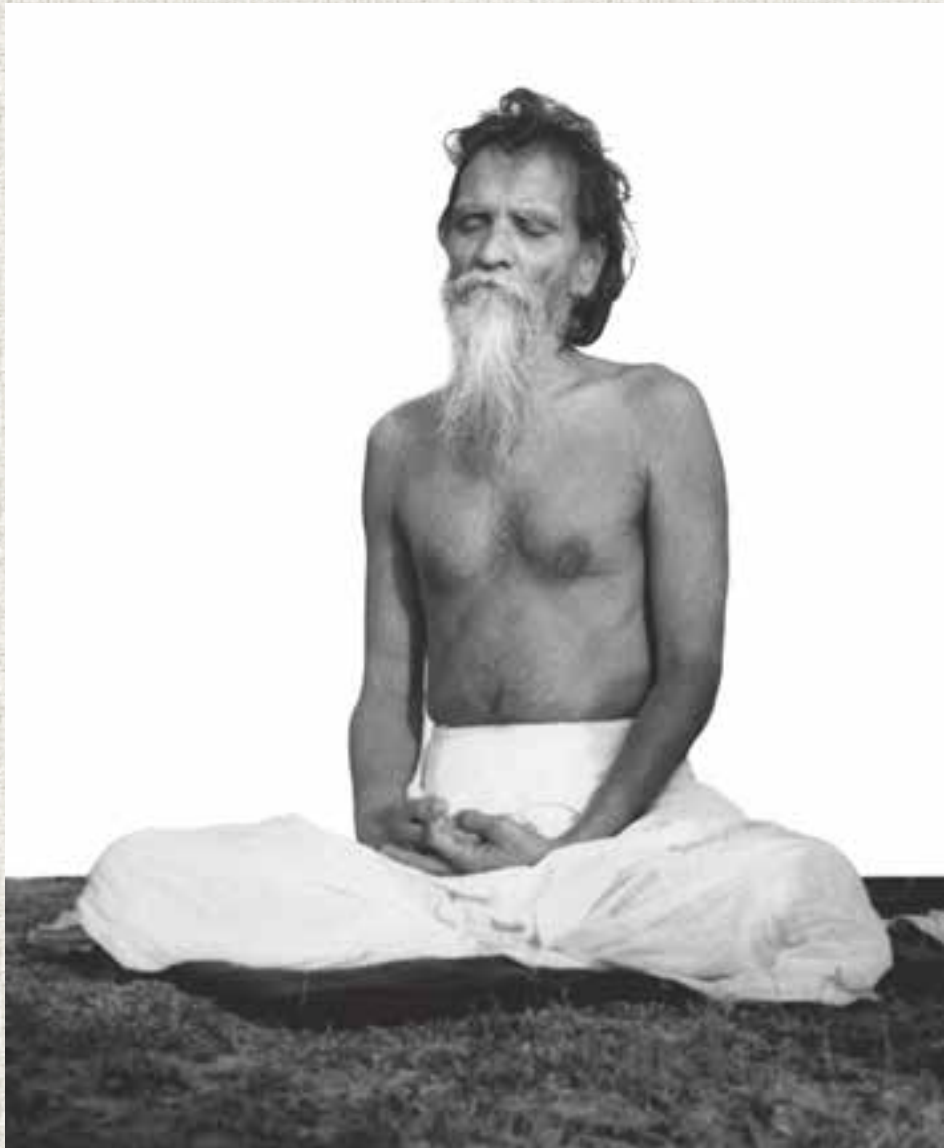
I have called this ashram a laboratory. Laboratories are not set up in the crowded markets; they need a secluded place. But all the instruments etc. are procured from the markets. Experiments are conducted under controlled conditions, but their results are useful for society. The *Ashram* is thus neither far from the society nor near it.



शांतं शिवं अद्वैतम्

Peace, Benevolence, Oneness

Brahmavidya-Mandir, Sukshma Karmayoga



We all must inculcate the habit of reflecting by going inside our inner sanctuary. We must distance ourselves from our work, ego, and even our dearest emotions.

If we practise detaching our *chitta* (mind) from our body, memory, experience, work and society around us, we will reach such a place which is the Primal Source—from where the world was created, where there was no body, no *chitta*, no world, but something was there.

Some call it Pure Existence, some call it Non-Existence and some call it Supreme Spirit. People grasp it as per their capacity and comprehension. But that is the only Primal Source. If we access that, the *chitta* will become extremely peaceful, pleasant and serene.

This is a matter of experience, not of imagination.



Cows in the Dham river-bed; Ashram in the background



Sanitation is a collective programme in the Ashram. For some time, Vinobaji had become 'sanitation commander' and the inmates had to stand up in a line and take orders like a battalion.



Physical labour is as essential, even more essential,
for spiritual progress as for material progress.



When we clean a place, it first becomes tolerable,
then it becomes clean, then beautiful, and finally it
becomes sacred. From tolerable to clean, from
clean to beautiful, from beautiful to sacred —
This is true for external cleanliness as well as for
internal cleanliness.



When *Karma Yoga* focuses on cleanliness, it is elevated to the status of *Dhyanyoga*.



For some time, Vinobaji used to spend three to four hours daily in cleaning the premises thoroughly, with attention to the most minute detail. For hours, he would pick up dried leaves and other waste matter. Once a visitor expressed surprise at this and wondered why he was wasting so much time and energy in such trivial work, when his services were sorely needed by the country. Vinobaji said, 'Well, you can take it as my stupidity!'

If instead of a broom, I had picked up a rosary, no one would have said that I was wasting my time! Picking up rubbish is, for me, like a rosary: with every straw picked up, there is remembrance of God.

A man who cannot tolerate rubbish around him will not tolerate rubbish inside him either.



A farm is an excellent gymnasium, an excellent temple for worship, and an excellent school. As the saying goes, the goddess of wealth resides on the tip of fingers. There is difference between wealth and money. Money can be had by theft, robbery, cheating, speculation, force, and what not. But agriculture is a productive work; therein lies wealth.



Breakfast in the field



Let us resolve to wield divine weapons like brooms, pick-axes, spades etc. as we have to do the Lord's work.

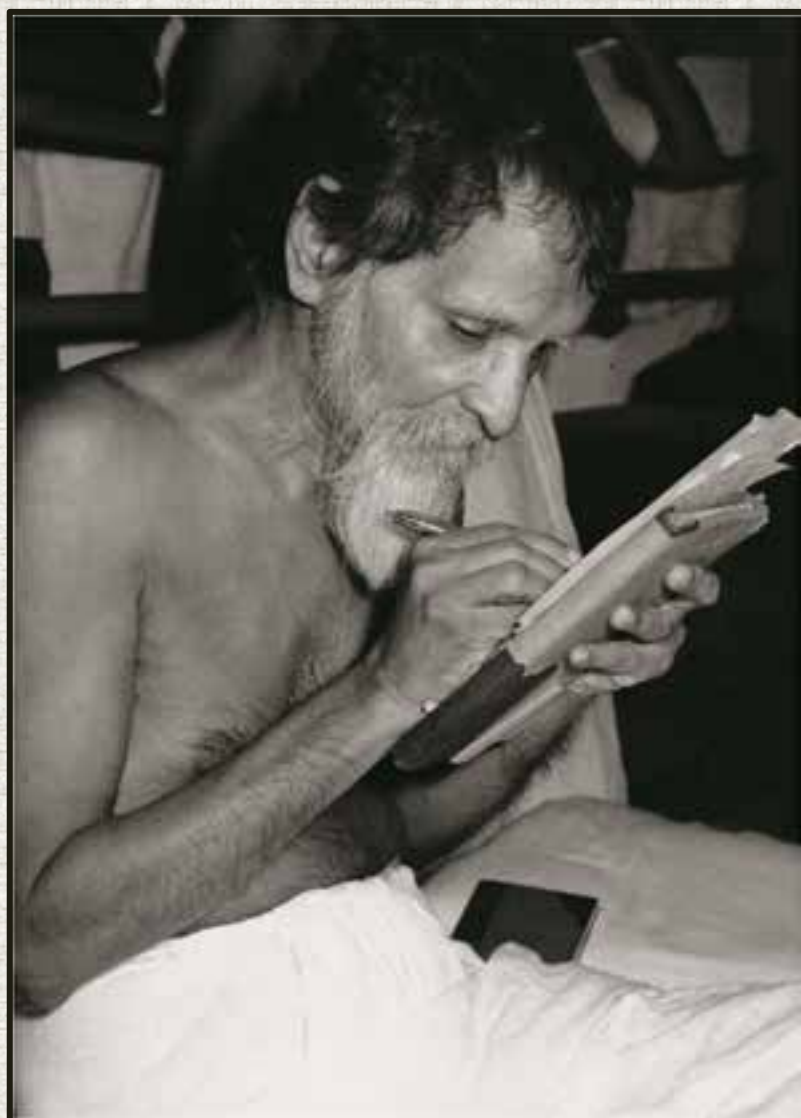


Land is not only a means of production; it is also a means of worshipping the Divine.

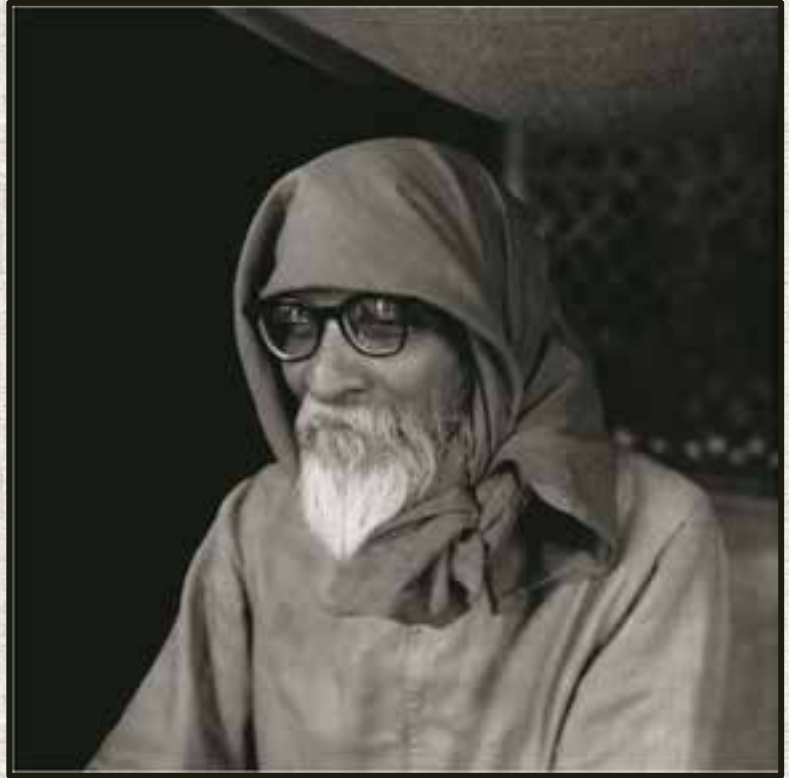


As a form of spiritual discipline, I have done various kinds of manual labour. However, I have experienced a special inner joy in agricultural work. For *Brahmacharya*, it is very beneficial to spend some time working in the fields every day.

Agriculture means oneness with nature and service to creation.



Both man and animal eat and drink. But animals cannot rise above their bodily needs, whereas a man has the capacity to stand apart from them. Inculcation of such a capacity constitutes true learning. As long as man does not develop this capacity, he remains a part of the material world; he cannot become a seer.



Mental satisfaction is an indication of the grace of God. It is the acknowledgement of his acceptance of our service.



When we read newspapers, it appears that a game of chess is going on, where the king, the queen and everything else are made of wood. Efforts may go on for boosting military might, for exploding atom bombs; all that is in vain. Ultimately, everything is bound to give way to non-violence. Ever since I realized this, I have been without a care in the world. In pleasure or in pain; it is the God's play that is going on.



In the life of a spiritual seeker selfless action, reflection and study do have a place, but the role of worship is the most important. It relates him to the Lord. Every action of ours should relate us to the Lord. We will have the key to achieve this through constant practice of worship.



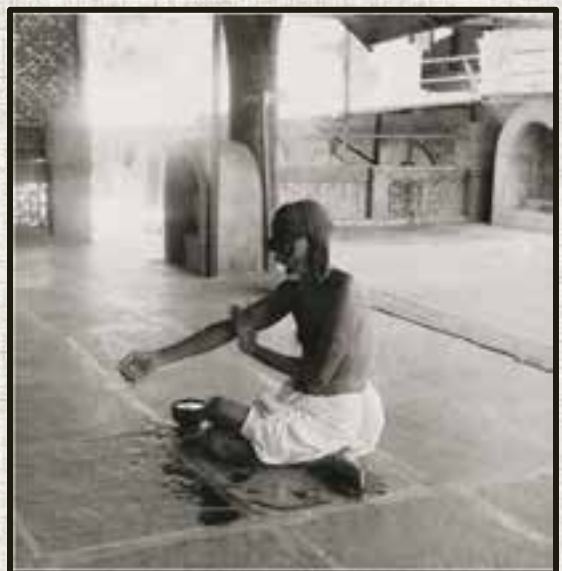
Helping Balubhai Mehta in performing exercises



Yogic exercises need no instruments or other means, need little space, besides being a quiet form of exercise.



A heater unnecessary; a coal stove serves the purpose.



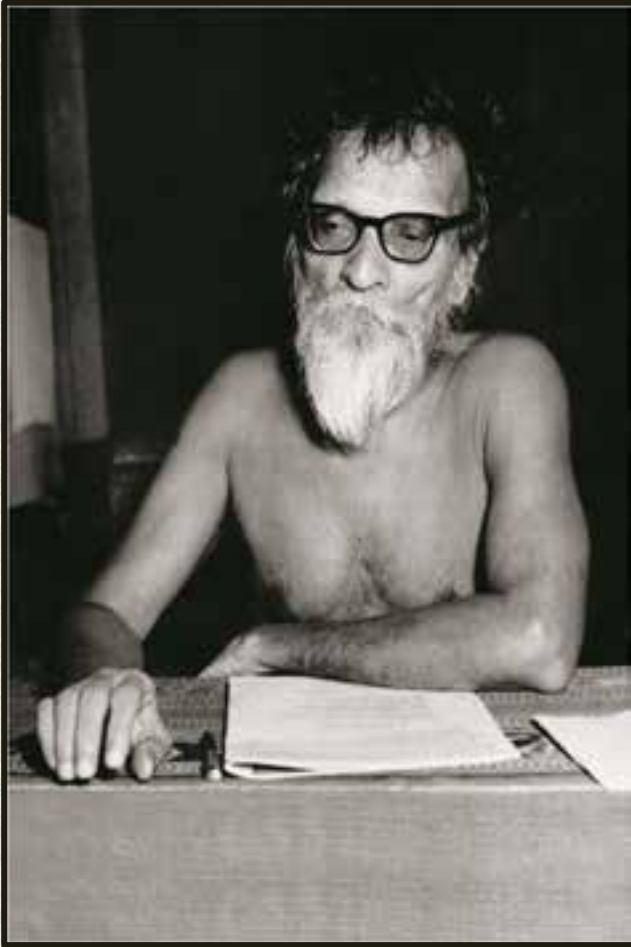
Beating the heat with cold water



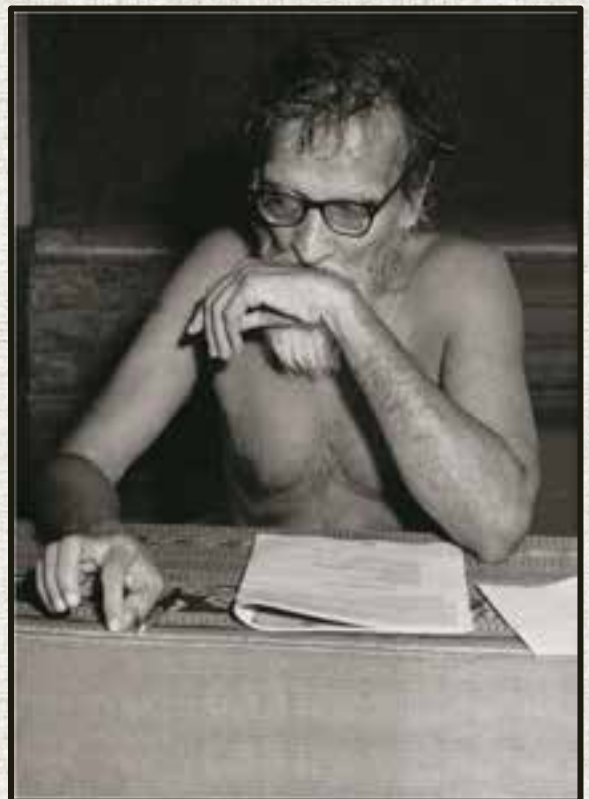
In English, music and painting are called fine arts. I call cooking a finer art. I have done cooking for many years and have induced others to do the same.



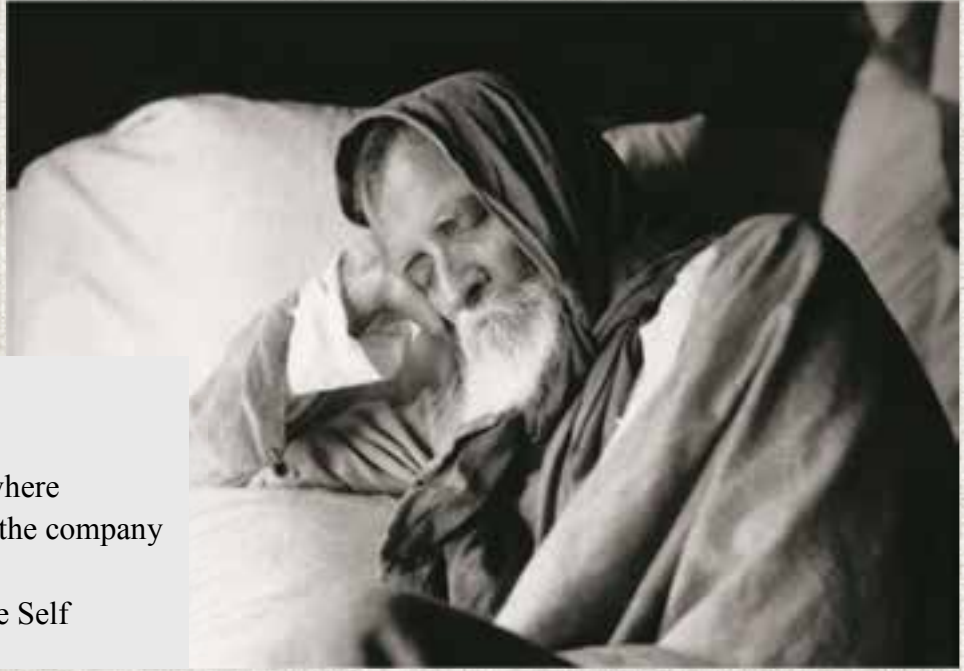
I observed that there is an effort in *ambar charkha* to combine science with non-violence. So I approved and welcomed it. I myself have spun on a single-spindle *ambar charkha* as well as a double-spindle one.
(*Vinobaji used to spin with both the hands.*)



The pattern of my life has been one of experiment on the basis of reflection and of reflection born of experiment. I call this reflection *nididhyasan*, a state of concentrated contemplation in which ideas flash into mind like living sparks.



The service that is done through reflection and meditation is much more than could be done through action.



Where do I stay?

The first answer is — Anywhere

The second answer is — In the company
of good and holy men

The third answer is — In the Self



With Balkoba and Shivaji, his brothers



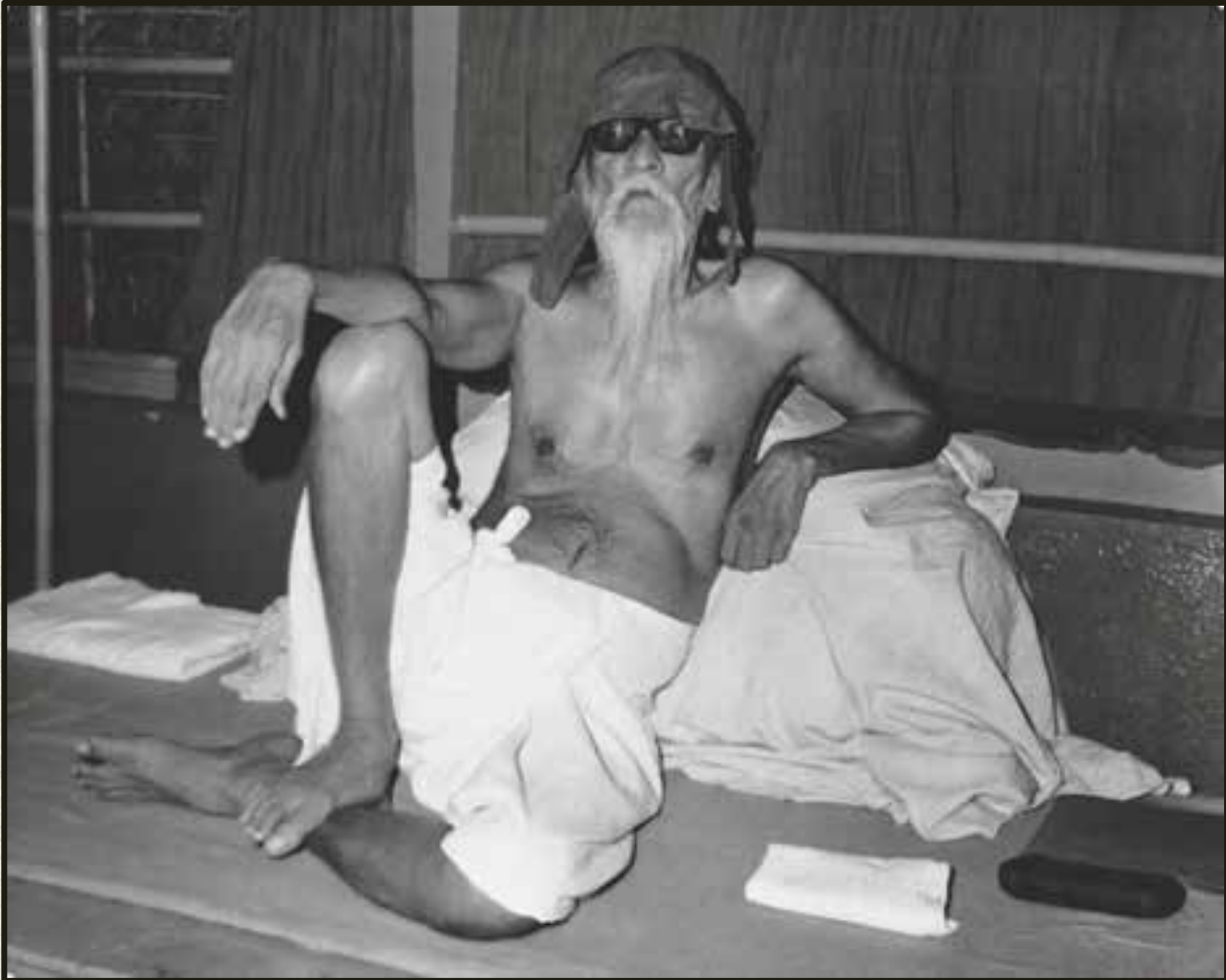
Among the villagers, who are praying for rain



A river is the incessant flow of God's compassion.



The river Dham in floods (1978)



These feet also know how to rest — ‘He moves and moves not’

I compare the free mind to the empty sky. Outwardly all-pervasive and inwardly void. In it the air flows, dust particles whirl around and rains occur, but the sky remains untouched. The sky’s only purpose is to give space to everything. In the same way even though I am constantly thinking and reflecting I remain untouched. This state of mind is the state of the free mind.



Distributing pieces of coconut



Observing the level of water in the well



Last rites of a cat



Inspection of the farm



Inauguration of the biogas plant — alternative fuel as a by-product from the dairy



Hinduism has provided for Holi to follow the principle of non-possession.



Listening to devotional songs from Smt. M.S. Subbulaxmi

Nothing can match music in turning the mind inward. These days music has become a slave to sensuality. But unite music with devotion and see how powerful it becomes! Music should rather be used for rendering melodious, morally elevating songs like those of Tulsidas and Soordas.



If we enjoy the game of chess irrespective of whether we win or lose, then that game will have a spiritual dimension. If the outcome makes us happy or unhappy, the game will remain on the mental plane.

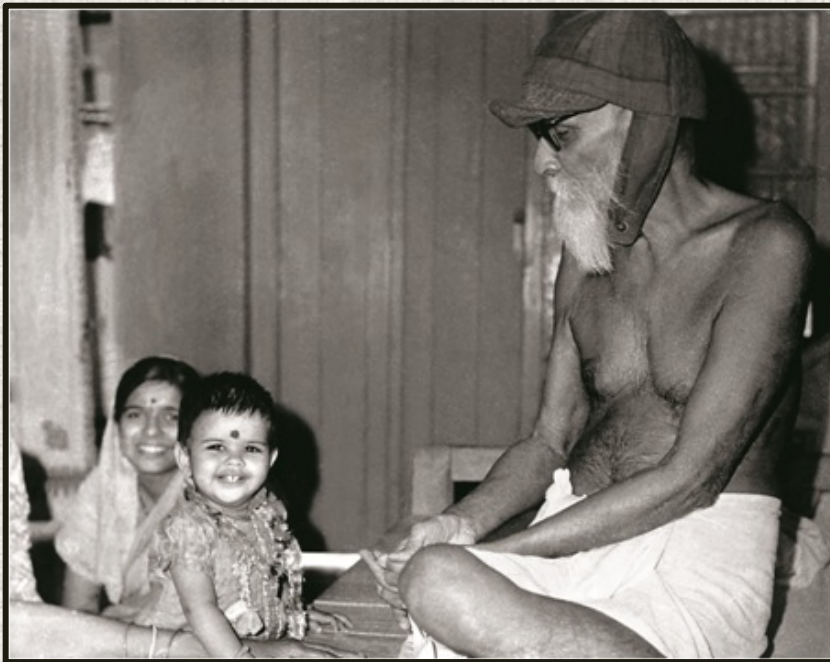
Playing chess with Balubhai Mehta



With a little friend at Madhubani (Bihar)



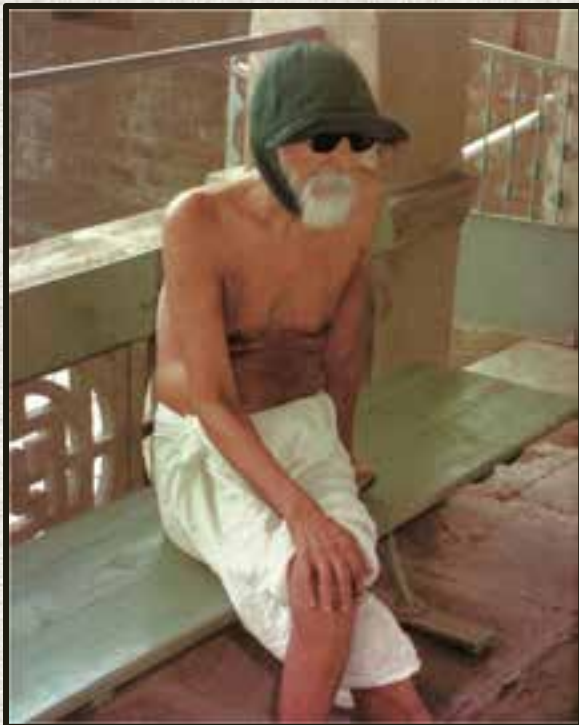
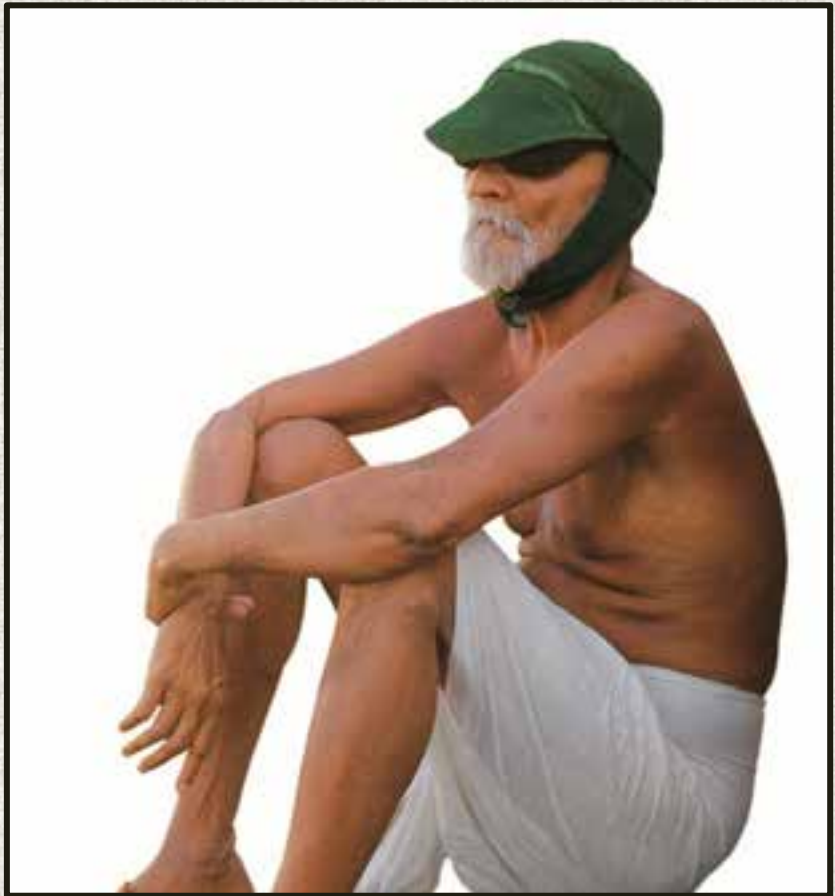
A cat and a dog too are members of the family!



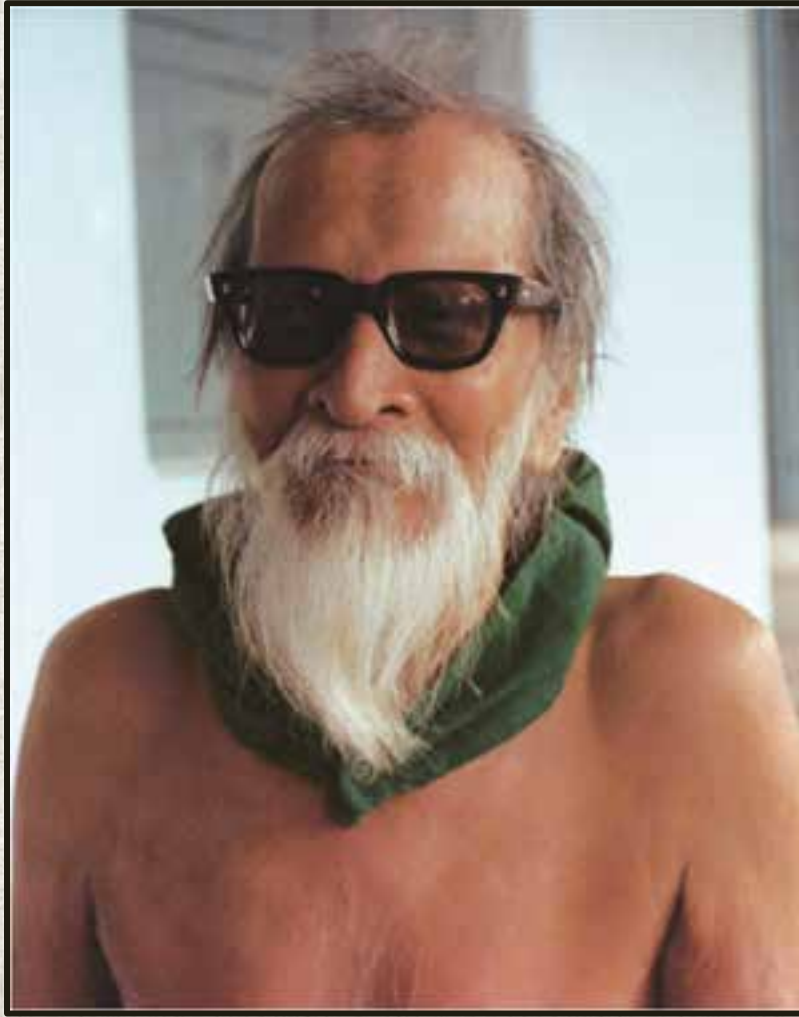
Children are a gift of God; they are nearer to Him. Let us not believe that it is up to us to shape their lives. It is enough if we ensure that their minds are not vitiated by harmful impressions.

Jesus was once asked, 'Who will be able to enter the Kingdom of heaven?' Jesus lifted a little child seated next to him and said, 'Those who are like this child will be able to do so.' Jesus' words are absolutely true.

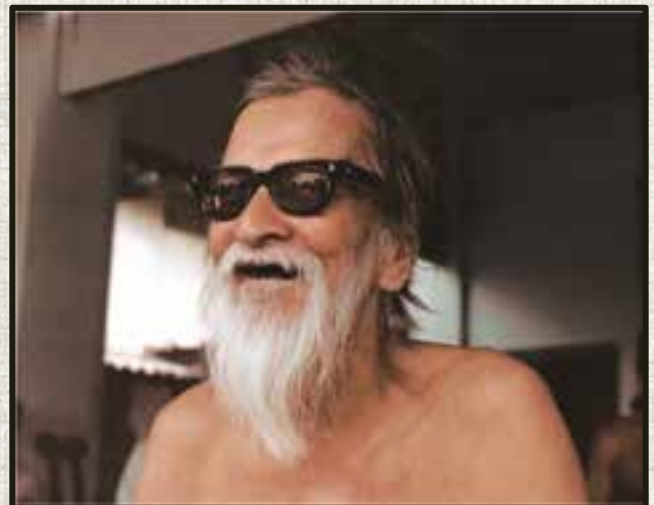
I am basically inclined to the way of renunciation even today. If somebody asks me which moment is the best in human life, I would say without hesitation that the moment when the mind is still, without any thought or emotion, is the moment to be treasured most. In this sense, I am a follower of the way of renunciation. Yet I appear to be engulfed in ceaseless action. This may appear contradictory, but it is not so. There is renunciation within and action without.



Far greater service to humanity can be rendered through contemplation and meditation than through action.



Word is more powerful than action, reflection is more powerful than word,
and silence is more powerful than reflection.



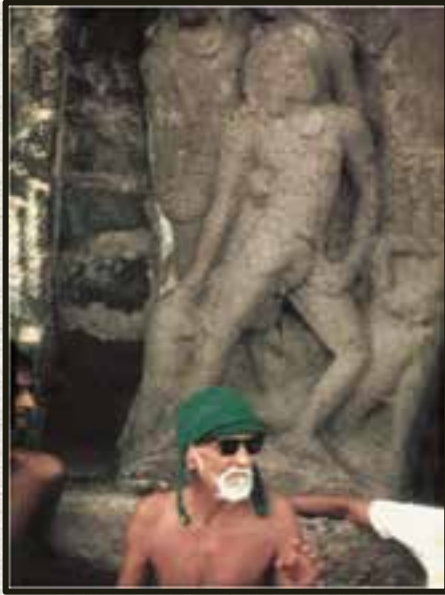
One who is self-reliant will always be happy; he will
be at peace with himself and with the world. Stream of
joy will flow continuously in his mind.



Nothing belongs to me. Everything belongs to me. I belong to everyone.



The music in the silent sky, the music in the inner recesses of the mind that accompanies breathing, the music that makes every act in the life harmonious—that is the real music.



In the course of digging, many stone images were unearthed in the (Pavnar) Ashram. These are about 1400 to 1500 years old. Most of them were damaged.

The image of goddess Ganga is just opposite my room in *Brahmavidya - Mandir*. I have been meditating on it. I found compassion in her eyes, peaceful joy on her face, affection in her bosom, and strength in her waist. Thus I got a host of attributes to meditate upon from a stone image.



The image of Lord Vishnu in black stone, about 1000 years old.

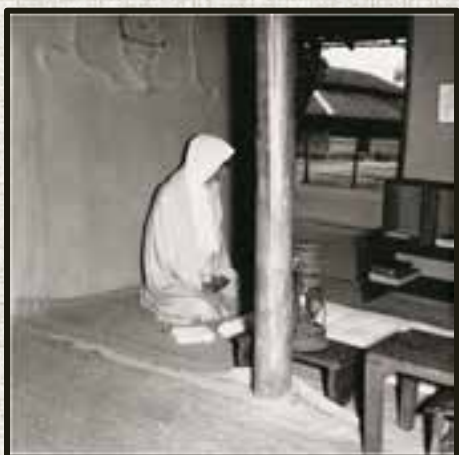




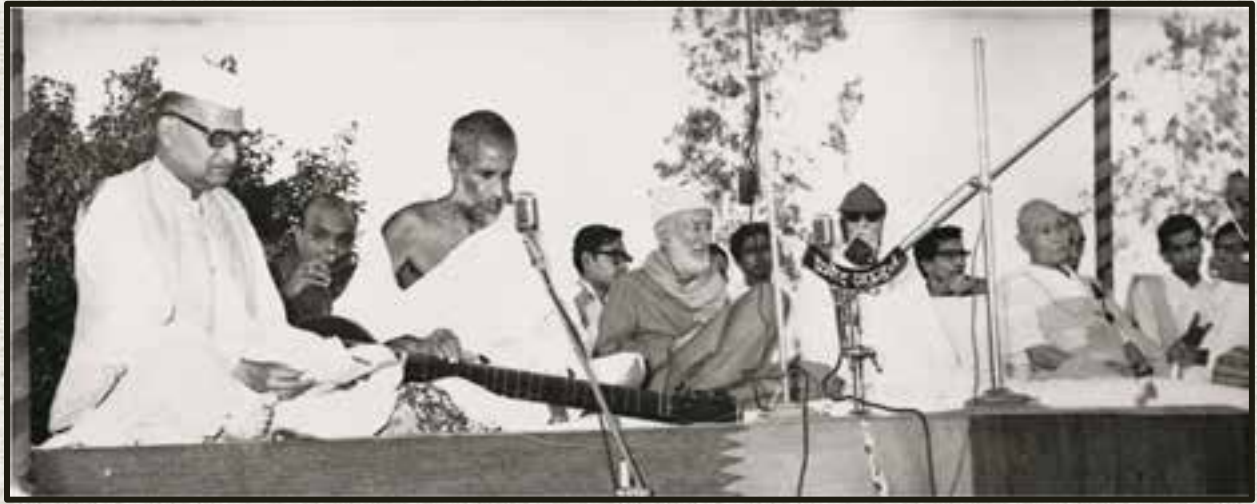
I have been a worshipful student and practitioner of different religions and cultures. While concentrating on any particular religion, it has been my practice to reflect upon the prominent names of God therein - - - In 1951 I composed three couplets which contain most of the prominent names in different religions. Yahwa (Jehovah) is the name dear to the Jews, Majda (Ahurmazda) to the Parsees, Ishu-Pita (Jesus' father) to the Christians, Rahim to the Muslims, Tao to the Chinese. This *Namamala* (garland of the names) beginning with *Om tat sat* includes the names pertaining to many of the sects in Hinduism as well.



For me a hank of handspun yarn symbolizes Gandhiji as nothing else can. His life is reflected therein to a greater degree than his photograph. I have therefore put before the country the programme of *Sootanjali* (presenting a hank of self-spun yarn) in Gandhiji's memory.



Since two days I have been sparing time to meditate in the *BapuKuti* (Gandhiji's hut at the *Sevagram Ashram*). In the context of that experience it appears to me that *BapuKuti* can best be utilized for meditation. The hut has something in it that touches and is bound to touch an inner chord in the mind of a man who is given to meditation and contemplation.



At the function for laying the foundation stone of Gitai Mandir with Kamalnayan Bajaj, Balkoba Bhave, Khan Abdul Gaffarkhan and Fuji Guruji of Japan



A view of the Gitai Mandir where 700 verses of the Gitai have been engraved on stone slabs.

Glimpses of Ashram activities

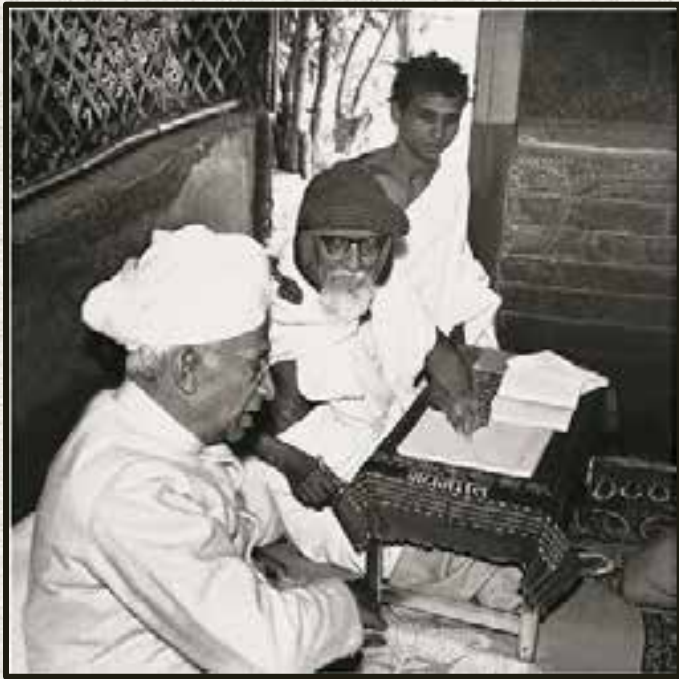




With Mr. Baker, the friend of the trees



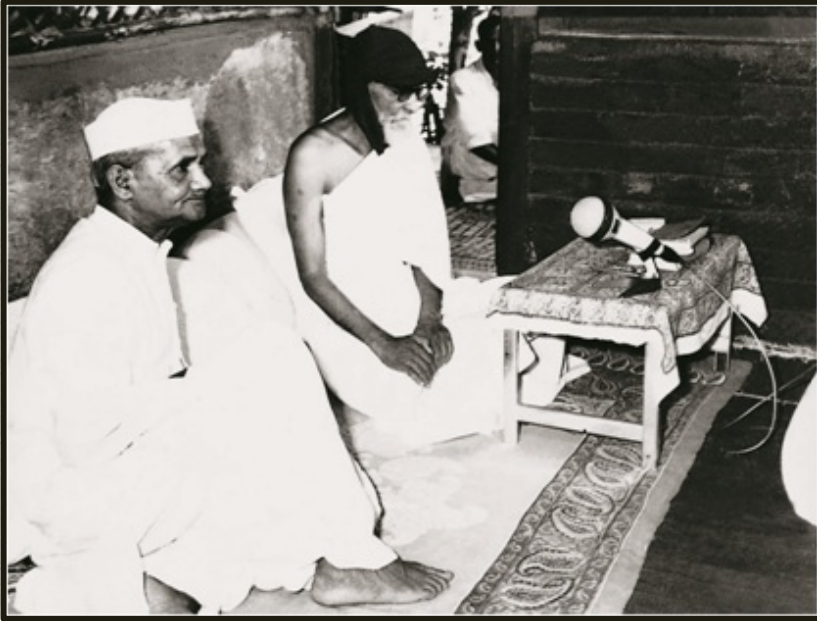
With D. K. Karve, a pioneer in women's education



With President Dr. S. Radhakrishnan



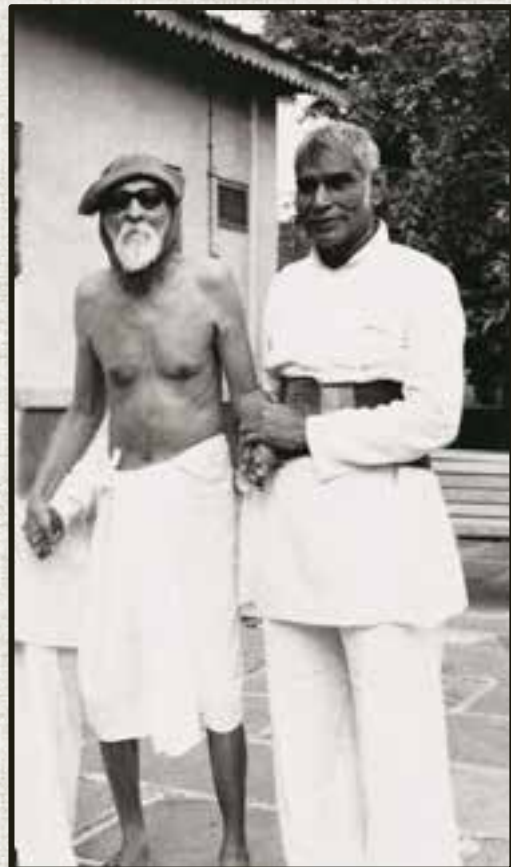
With Prime Minister Smt. Indira Gandhi



With Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri



With Acharya Tulsi



With Baba Amte



With Lanza del Vasto (called Gandhi of France)



With Shrikrishnadas Jajoo



With Khan Abdul Gaffarkhan



With Swami Ramsukhdasji



The cow is like our mother. So, killing a cow is tantamount to killing our own mother.

A cow embodies the message of Indian culture. Worship of the cow is one of the best thoughts in Hinduism. Cow's milk deserves a more prominent place on India's agenda than even *khadi*. Milking of the cow is a discovery that has taken us a step forward on the path of non-violence; it has made possible for man to abjure meat-eating.

In India, a cow is a part of the human family. Our rural economy is cow-centred. We have deep reverence for the cow. We should also love her and serve her properly.



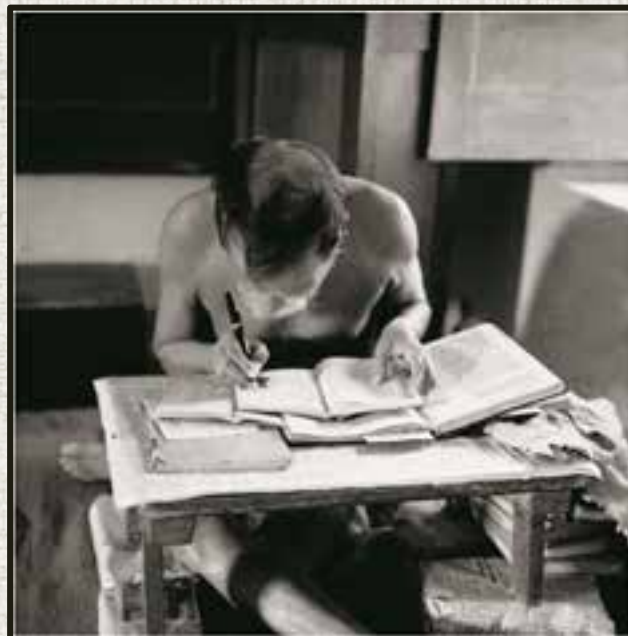
In the Acharya Conference at Pavnar (1976)

To continue the pursuit of knowledge, to study the problems of society dispassionately and evolve consensus within the group regarding their solutions, to put before the people that consensus for their guidance—these are the objectives with which I have founded the *Acharyakul*.

The thinking of politicians is biased, and therefore it is not holistic and right. So, people can follow their guidance at their own peril. The country needs guidance from dispassionate men of wisdom and learning, expressed in appropriate words. That will save the country.

Acharyakul will have in its fold teachers, scientists, writers, judges, journalists, and all others who are non-partisan and think in a balanced way.

These *acharyas* will be fearless, free from enmity towards anybody, and non-partisan.

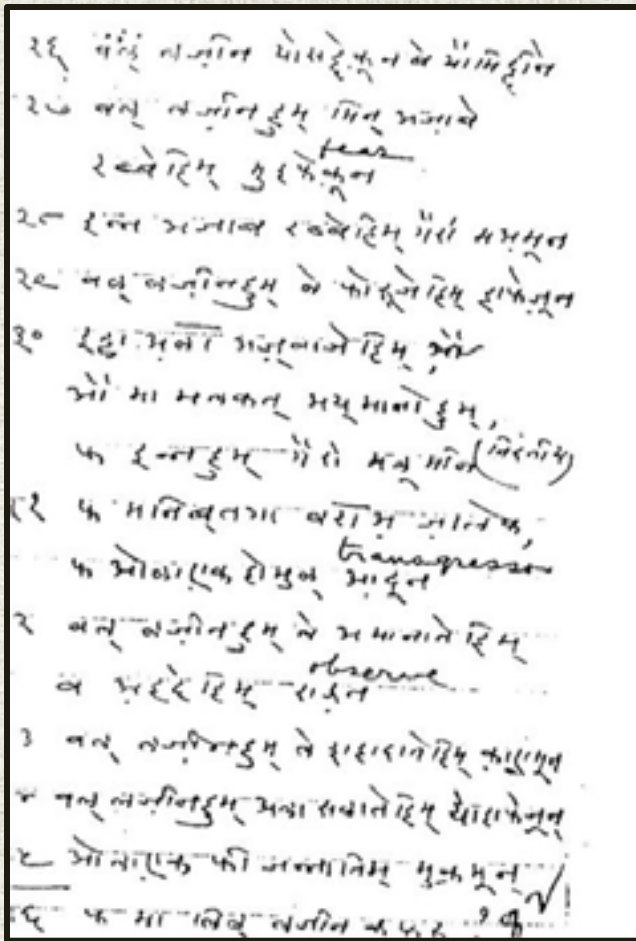


Selecting verses from the Rig Veda

The *Vedas* seek to arouse spiritual consciousness in man; that is their main object.

The *Vedas* lay stress on worship. There is no nature-worship in them; there is worship of the divine essence manifested in different forms. They also lay stress on meditation. Reflection on God's manifestations develops different virtues in us. There is no polytheism. It is said therein: 'God is one, but the devotees give Him different names.'

A question is often asked, "Why should we prefer the older treatises to the modern ones?" In Homoeopathy, medicines are pulverized continuously to increase their potency. Millions of people and great men have reflected upon the ancient treatises again and again, thereby enhancing their potency. Besides, they have withstood the test of time. How many of the present writings will be read after a hundred years?



Vinobaji used to write down Arabic verses in the Nagari script while studying the Quran. 'The Essence of the Quran' has been published in the Nagari script also.

Throughout my life, all my activities have been motivated by the single objective of uniting hearts. That is the motivation behind 'The Essence of the Quran' also.

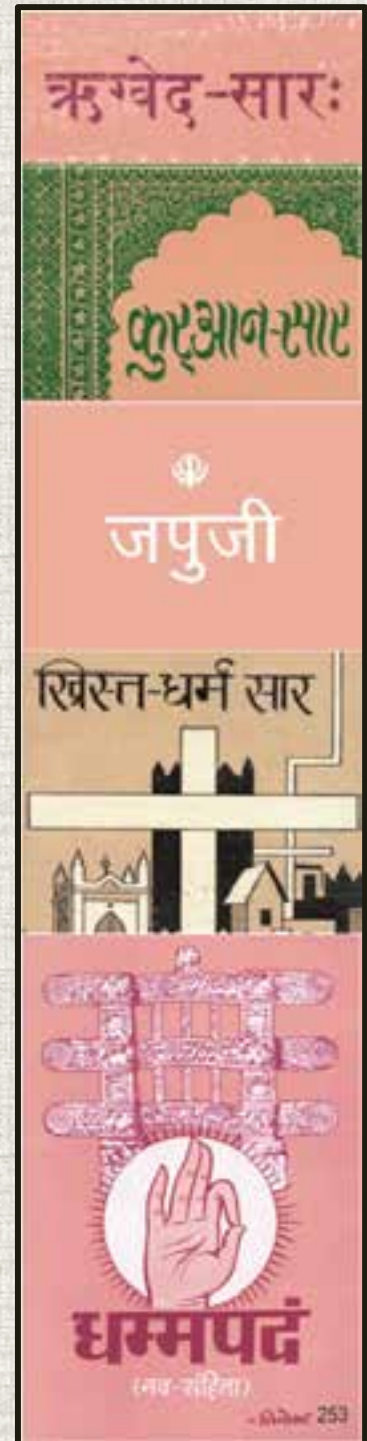
Quran stresses on three things: Truth, patience and compassion.

'Japuji' contains the essence of the spiritual vision of the Sikh faith. It enjoins the worship of God as Truth. Fearlessness and absence of enmity are the two words that embody the spiritual pursuit delineated by 'Japuji'.

Jesus' three commandments:

1. Love thy neighbour as thyself
2. Love thy enemy
3. Love each other

Dhammapada is a collection of disconnected maxims, not a systematic presentation. It is a form that veils its philosophy. When I studied the '*Dhammapada*' in depth, its verses arranged themselves in my mind in a particular sequence. I felt that I should place it before the people. I have humbly ventured to do so in the form of *Dhammapada-Navsanhita*.





Prayer is not to be done with an eye on a seat in the heaven. It is to be done for the purification of heart, for social integration, for becoming absorbed in the Self.

The secret of prayer lies in delving deep into the Self.

Prayer is the most important part of our life. It is like the lungs. One should spend the whole day waiting for the prayer time eagerly and fervently. Prayer takes little time, but it is the mainstay of all our daily activities.



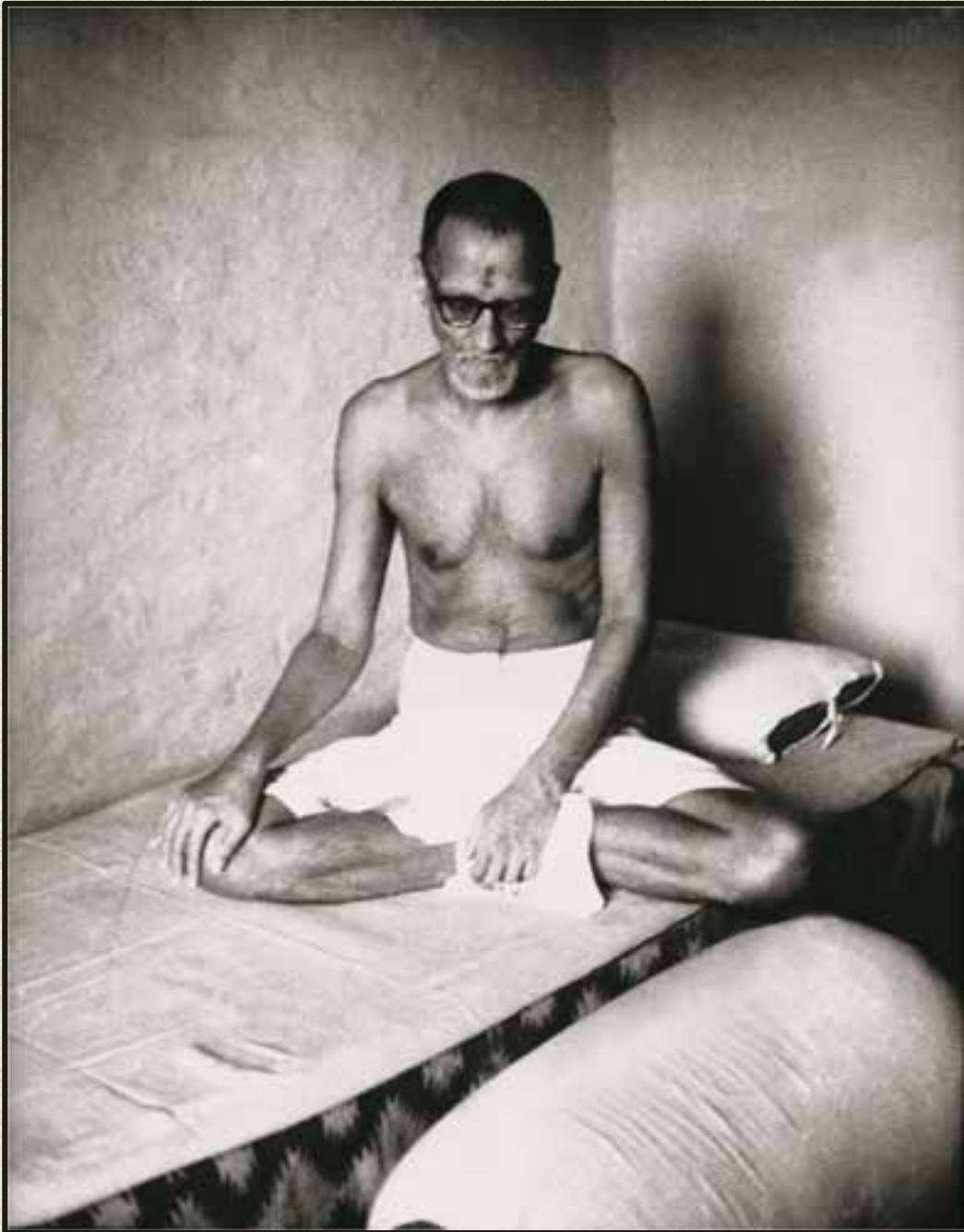
There was a time when I relied much on (Self-) knowledge, but experience has taught me that knowledge alone is not enough. It can burn down gross impurities in the mind, but is powerless to wash away subtler impurities. Subtle impurities can be washed away only by the waters of devotion.



In prayer we try to establish communion with the Lord. But in sleep we actually rest in His lap.

Sleep is the rehearsal of death. Before going to sleep we should have the feeling that we are going to die and will shortly be in His lap. If we sleep with this thought, our mind would be turned to God in the last moment. If we want to have Him in the mind at the time of death, we should daily carry out the rehearsal of death at the time of sleeping.

Just as a seed germinates under the cover of the soil, thoughts develop in a dreamless sleep.



Outward activities chisel the mind; I therefore decided to enter upon the hidden, more deeply inward path of action. It implies expansion of consciousness; its secret lies in becoming like sky. Sky has space; it allows for light. But it is not attached to that light, nor is it limited to whatever happens within its space. That is how the mind should become.



The last journey (16-11-1982)

***Let this life merge in the all-conscious and eternal being; and let the body be reduced to ashes - - -
(Ishavasya Upanishad, 17)***